Dream with Us High School Engineering Design Challenge

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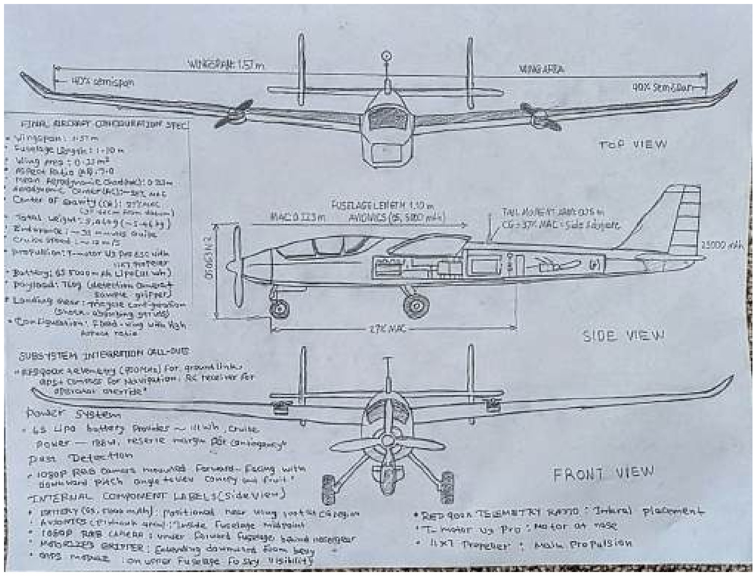

Design Name

TerraScan

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Submitted by AeroField

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Submission Date: 1/23/2025

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Table of Contents

List of Figures

List of Tables

Executive Summary

The apple industry in Washington state accounts for over two billion dollars annually. One damaging pest is codling moth which left unchecked can destroy up to 80 percent of an apple crop. Farmers generally combat pests through area-wide spraying of insecticides and expensive hand checks of fruit for damage. To address the difficulty and expense of detection and sampling codling moth damage, we built an uncrewed aircraft system (UAS) to autonomously detect codling moth damage present in orchards, while also taking physical samples of fruit for later analysis in a lab. Detection of pest damage coupled with physical sampling allow farmers to effectively target pests and make better-informed pest management decisions while reducing environmental impact and overall cost.

Our aircraft has a 1.57-meter wingspan and was designed with endurance in mind. Flight time of approximately 35 minutes is achieved on a rechargeable lithium-polymer battery which enables coverage of 100 acres in three missions with a battery change in between each mission. We chose to build a fixed-wing aircraft instead of a multirotor due to its endurance advantage, lower mechanical complexity, and reliable design that has been built by high-schoolers in the past.

Payload for pest damage detection consists of an ultra-lightweight 1080p RGB camera. Mounted beneath the nose fuselage, the camera obtains a ground sampling distance of 5 centimeters when flying at 60 meters providing enough resolution to identify codling moth entry holes and staining from frass on apples. Computer vision algorithm executed in three major steps identifies regions of images that contain fruit, identifies if and where damage is found on the fruit, and tags these locations with GPS coordinates to produce a map of pest pressure in the field of interest.

Payload for sample acquisition consists of a motorized mechanical gripper mounted to a linear actuator which can extend 30 centimeters past the bottom of the fuselage. The gripper can then actuate to acquire a fruit sample which it can bring inside the aircraft body and securely store in a 12-slot foam container for sample storage. The contained can be cooled upon completion of the mission to preserve the fruit samples until they can be examined in a laboratory.

Ground station for this aircraft was designed to be operated by two people. One person would be assigned to fly the aircraft while maintaining visual line-of-sight, while the other would be responsible for monitoring telemetry and triggering sample acquisition. All components necessary for the operation of this aircraft can fit into hard cases allowing for protection during transport. Set up of this aircraft can be done in under 30 minutes allowing for same-day operations at multiple sites if necessary.

Overall system cost comes to around $6,200 with operating costs around $90 per mission. Though this may seem expensive at first, consider that damage from codling moth is estimated to cause five-hundred million dollars of damage to crops in Washington state alone. With our compact UAS farmers can detect pest damage within their orchards while also sampling apples to confirm their suspicions. Early detection of pests allows for more precise pesticide use which could reduce environmental impact and allow for more sustainable farming in the pacific northwest.

1. Introduction

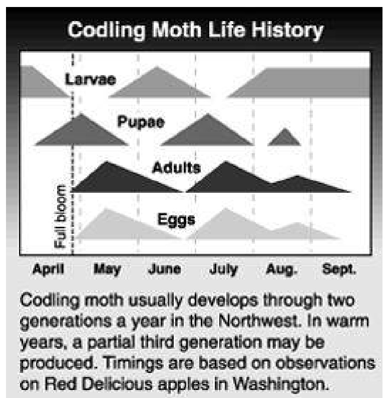
1.1 Local Agricultural Pest

The team decided to choose codling moth (Cydia pomonella) as our local agricultural pest because of its significant negative economic impact on apple crops in Washington and its pervasiveness throughout the history of King County, Washington. Currently, the team resides in Bothell, WA, within King County .Codling moth is known to be the most economically damaging insect pest of apple (Malus domestica) and pear (Pyrus spp.) crops worldwide and costs Washington apple growers millions of dollars each year.

Photo of Codling Moth Damage to Apple. Signs and symptoms of a codling moth larvae infested apple. Note the brown material (frass) being pushed out from larval entry holes and the dark red discoloration about each hole. [Bush, Michael. "Apple-Codling Moth." *Pacific Northwest Pest Management Handbooks*, Washington State University Extension, Oregon State University, and University of Idaho, https://pnwhandbooks.org/insect/tree-fruit/apple/apple-codling-moth. Accessed 31 Dec. 2025.]

Pest Biology and Description

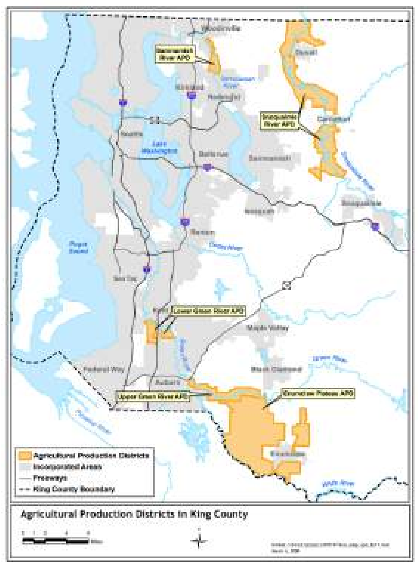
Codling moth is a small moth of the family Tortricidae, more commonly known as “leafrollers”. Adult moths have a wingspan ranging from 15-20 millimeters and are gray with dark zigzag patterns and a copper-colored band across each wing. Codling moth in Washington will complete two to three generations each year depending on the accumulated degree days (DD) (base 50°F). In warmer microclimates with longer growing seasons, like the Yakima growing region, codling moth can have partial generations 4 each season. There are four life stages of codling moth including egg, larva, pupa, and adult. Female moths lay eggs one at a time on leaves, fruit, or bark close to developing fruit. Each female can lay up to 100 eggs throughout her lifespan. Eggs take 6-20 days to hatch, depending on temperature (higher temperature allows for faster development). When larvae hatch they immediately crawl toward the closest fruit, usually entering through the calyx or stem end. Once inside the fruit larvae will tunnel toward the core eating the seeds and fruit surrounding the seed. Larvae feed inside of the fruit causing damage which makes the fruit unsellable and allowing an open wound for pathogens to enter. Larvae will develop through five instars over the course of their 3-4 week feeding period increasing in size from 1 mm to about 20 mm. After feeding, larvae will exit fruit and move to protected locations under bark, in soil, or under tree debris to pupate. Overwintering larvae will be in diapause throughout Washington winters and are able to withstand temperatures as low at -20°F with sufficient coverage.



Codling Moth Lifecycle Diagram. Seasonal timing of codling moth life stages showing egg, larva, pupa, and adult phases across two generations per year in the Pacific Northwest. Chart illustrates generation overlap and timing from April through September based on observations in Washington state. [Brunner, Jay. "Codling Moth Biology and Ecology." *WSU Tree Fruit*, Washington State University, 21 Feb. 2024, https://treefruit.wsu.edu/crop-protection/opm/duplicated-codling-moth-biology-and-ecology/. Accessed 31 Dec. 2025.]

Affected Plants and Geographic Distribution

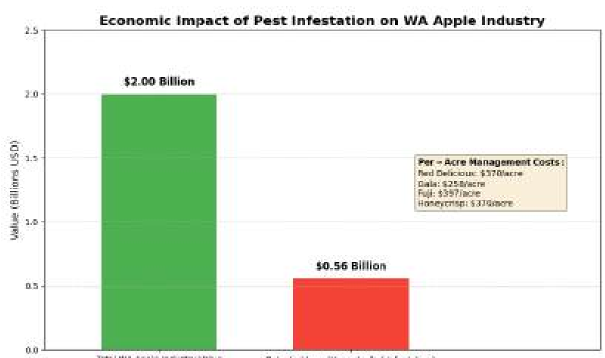
The primary hosts of codling moth are apple trees (Malus domestica) and pear trees (Pyrus spp.). Codling moth also attacks walnut (Juglans spp.), quince (Cydonia oblonga), apricot, and plum (Prunus spp.) but with much lower instances of infestation. There are no apple varieties that are immune to codling moth however some apple varieties with thicker skins or higher levels of natural tannins have been shown to decrease larval penetration. Apples are a $2 billion dollar industry in Washington and rank first in production in the United States. King county used to be know for having more apple trees than any other county west of the Cascade Mountain; however, today's agricultural practices have diversified. There were 1,604 farms in King county in 2022 that covered 46,261 acres and produced $102.7 million in agriculture sale. Even though our area has diversified we still produce fruits, tree nuts, and berries worth $3.2 million a year. King county is comprised of 19,170 acres of crop land. Out of the 19,170 acres of crop land the largest category is Nursery and Greenhouse (44.8 million), Dairy Products (31 million), and Vegetables (8.3 million). The Puget Sound region grows berries, vegetables, and tree fruit. Apple and pear continue to be one of the largest crops produced in western Washington.



Geographic Map of King County Agricultural Areas. Map showing King County boundaries with Agricultural Production Districts (APDs) highlighted in orange, including Bothell's location in the northern part of the county. Major agricultural zones include the Snoqualmie River Valley APD east of Bothell, Lower Green River APD south of Seattle, and Enumclaw Plateau APD in southeastern King County. ["Agricultural Production Districts in King County." *King County Department of Natural Resources and Parks*, March 2007, https://your.kingcounty.gov/dnrp/library/VCGIS/xfer/ADAP_WSU/05March2007/final_adap_apd.pdf. Accessed 31 Dec. 2025.]

Economic Impact on Local Agricultural Industry

Codling moth damage can cause serious threat to the economic viability of Washington agriculture. According to research conducted by WSU if populations of codling moth were to reach unmanageable levels it could destroy 80% of NW apple crops and 50% of pear crops. Damage thresholds for codling moth is only 1-2% damaged fruit; past this point producers should try to take immediate action to reduce damage. Before integrated pest management techniques were established, growers were losing an average of 10-25% of their crop yield to codling moth each year. Currently, managing codling moth takes a large financial toll on growers. Apple and pear growers in Washington previously sprayed almost 2 million pounds of insecticides per year specifically to combat codling moth and secondary pests. It costs growers anywhere from $60-$150 per acre to manage codling moth. To give some perspective on how much damage a pest can cause to the apple industry WSU's school of economic science did an analysis on how apple maggot (Rhagoletis pomonella; quarantine pest for WA apples) would affect Washington's economy if it were to become established in areas where it is not currently present. If apple maggot were to infest these areas apple production in Washington would lose $510-557 million in total output value depending on codling moth pressure. Low codling moth pressure would cost threatened areas an additional $370.46, $396.53, and $257.50 per acre to control apple maggots for Red Delicious, Fuji, and Gala apples respectively. High codling moth pressure would lessen this cost because sprayers would already be applying heavy spray programs that would mitigate additional pests.



Economic Impact of Codling Moth on Washington Apple Industry. Bar chart illustrating the economic scale of codling moth impacts including: Washington apple industry value ($2 billion in fresh sales, $9.5 billion total economic contribution), potential losses from unmanaged pest infestations ($510-557 million), per-acre management costs by variety ($257-396/acre for Red Delicious, Gala, Fuji, and Honeycrisp), and historical potential crop losses from uncontrolled codling moth populations (up to 80-90% of crop). [Gallardo, R. Karina, and Suzette P. Galinato. "Economic Impact of Apple Maggot Infestation in Washington." *Washington State University Extension*, 2016, https://treefruitresearch.org/wp-content/uploads/2019/11/Report-801.-GallardoAppleMaggotFinal-002.pdf . Accessed 31 Dec. 2025.]

Resource Justification and Pest Selection Process

Our decision to choose codling moth over other prevalent pests was made with the use of many resources. We used online extensions provided by Washington State University Tree Fruit Research and Extension Center, Pacific Northwest Pest Management Handbooks, WSU Integrated pest management, WSU Decision Aid System for degree days, and economic impact studies from WSU school of economic science. We also looked at information provided by Washington State Department of Agriculture on quarantine pests and the USDA Agricultural Research Services on integrated pest management of pests in Washington. While Codling moth was not the first pest picked, it took priority over many others due to many reasons. Codling moth has been in the PNW for over a century and is the largest concern for apple growers throughout all of Washington. Not only does codling moth have a very low acceptable damage threshold of 1-2% but because their larvae feed within the fruit one larva can ruin an entire apple. With a huge concern for one pest large amount of spray is needed throughout the season. Many other pests we looked at overlap with codling moth spray times. By effectively managing codling moth, growers can reduce the amount of spray needed to manage all pests. Codling moth also completes three full generations in the season which will require continuous scouting and monitoring, making them ideal for UAS detection..

Criterion	**Codling Moth**	**Spotted-Wing Drosophila**	**Apple Maggot**	**Pear Psylla**
Economic Impact (WA)	$510-557M potential losses; 80-90% crop loss if uncontrolled	~$500-718M annual US damage; severe for organic ops	$547-557M if spreads to all WA areas; + storage costs	Most destructive to WA pear industry; fruit quality downgrades
Detection Difficulty	Moderate (internal larvae, requires trapping)	Difficult (small flies, attacks ripening fruit directly)	High (no external holes, internal maggots)	Moderate (visible on leaves, multiple generations)
Host Plants	Apple, pear, walnut, quince (Narrow range)	Very wide range (berries, cherries, stone fruits, wild hosts)	Apple, pear, crabapple (Restricted)	Pear only (Very specific)
Management Costs	$257-396/acre	Variable (high for organic due to limited insecticides)	$111-396/acre (+ quarantine storage costs)	$1,000-1,500/acre (Highest cost)

Comparison of Washington Agricultural Pests

Our team understands that those outside of Washington agriculture might not understand the big deal about codling moth. Codling moth is not an outside feeding insect that creates cosmetic injury, they tunnel into the core of fruit. When one fruit is infested it often goes unnoticed until major injury is done. One worm can make an apple unfit for sale. Consumers expect their fruits to be free of pests. Any time there is a detection of codling moth in a load, it will be rejected by the processor or exporter. Codling moth are one pest that has a zero tolerance and needs to be monitored closely and quickly, which is where our UAS will be most useful.

1.2 Team Organization

The group consisted of three members who were all seniors at Bothell High School in Bothell, Washington. The group utilized a distributed leadership model and each leader was assigned their own specific technical domain of responsibility. Technical decisions were made by the lead expert in that particular field regardless of role hierarchy. This is similar to how leadership would be handled in a real-world aerospace engineering team as each technical expert acts as a leader in their field, but are on the same level as other experts. Members were each assigned their own sections to work on. However, integration between each section was heavily collaborated on to create a unified system that satisfied the design requirements set forth by the NASA Dream with Us competition.

Operations and Business Lead: Ritvik Rajkumar

As the Operations and Business Lead, Ritvik Rajkumar was responsible for project scheduling and tracking, Gantt charts, task dependencies, technical handoffs, resource constraints, and the business case. With a strong background in math, Rajkumar was able to handle all of the cost calculations, dollar figures, and other mathematical relations needed for the Business Case (Section 4). By working closely with the Technical Lead and Mission Lead, Rajkumar was able to relate decisions that they made on the design front to how it would affect the schedule and budget. lthough he was not directly responsible for designing the system, as operations lead he had to make sure that the system that was being designed would still meet schedule, cost, and logistical constraints. This mirrors the responsibilities of an engineering team in the real world because one cannot have a perfect design if it does not consider these factors.

Technical Lead: Risith Kankanamge

As technical lead, Risith Kankanamge was responsible for leading the design of the systems engineering, subsystem architecture, and technical decisions of the air vehicle, command and control (C3) system, and payloads. Essentially, any lead making decisions on how the actual system would be built was made by Risith. He was chosen to be the technical lead because he had previously been the software lead on the Robotics club's software team at Bothell High School. Additionally, Risith plans on majoring in computer science which allowed him to have a strong background in programming.

Mission Lead: Santhosh Ilaiyaraja

As Mission Lead, Santhosh Ilaiyaraja was responsible for the mission performance calculations, computer modeling, and energy budgeting. These responsibilities allowed Santhosh to really dive into how the air vehicle, our payload, and operational procedures would come together to perform our benchmark mission. He was chosen to be mission lead because of his strong computational skills and background in math. Santhosh took the lead on Sections 2.3.3 (Payload – Pest Detection) and 2.3.4 (Payload – Sample Gathering). This model was given to the Technical Lead and used as a reference to design the air vehicle. As Mission Lead, Santhosh had lead responsibility for Section 3 (Mission Discussion).

Collaborative Decision-Making and Cross-Functional Integration

Technically, each of the three co-leads owned a separate area of the project. Decision making was done primarily through technical heads and not due to one person being over another person. For example, if there was a design decision that branched into other areas (Payload weight limitations effecting air vehicle design, Communication architecture effecting both C3 and DAA etc.), all three technical leads would meet and come to a decision after a technical trade-off discussion. All ideas were heard and then met the requirements of the mission. Each co-lead would peer review each other's written documents that fell into their technical field.

Skills Distribution and Domain Responsibility Summary

Ritvik Rajkumar (Operations and Business Lead)

- **Core Domain Expertise:** Project management, timeline coordination, cost analysis, financial modeling, business strategy
- **Technical Contributions:** Mathematical reasoning applied to cost calculations, economic analysis, strategic planning

- **Sections Where Lead Authority:** 2.2 (Project Plan), 4 (Business Case), 6 (Conclusion)
- **Cross-Functional Collaboration:** Coordinate between Technical and Mission leads; ensure design decisions are captured in timeline and budget

Risith Kankanamge (Technical Lead)

- **Core Domain Expertise:** Systems engineering, software architecture, control systems design, technical integration, hardware/software interfaces
- **Technical Contributions:** Subsystem integration, design trade studies, center of gravity analysis, propulsion selection, command and control specification
- **Sections Where Lead Authority:** 2.1 (Engineering Design Process), 2.3.1 (Air Vehicle), 2.3.2 (C3), 3.3.1 (Detect and Avoid)
- **Cross-Functional Collaboration:** Receive mission requirements from Mission Lead; provide air vehicle performance data to support Mission Lead analysis

Santhosh Ilaiyaraja (Mission Lead)

- **Core Domain Expertise:** Mission analysis, computational modeling, sensor systems, energy budgeting, safety engineering, quantitative analysis
- **Technical Contributions:** Payload design, mission performance calculations, benchmark mission analysis, safety protocols, contingency procedures
- **Sections Where Lead Authority:** 2.3.3 (Payload – Pest Detection), 2.3.4 (Payload – Sample Gathering), 3.1 (Concept of Operations), 3.2 (Benchmark Mission), 3.3 (Safety Requirements)
- **Cross-Functional Collaboration:** Drive mission requirements that inform Technical Lead's air vehicle design; provide quantitative justification for system specifications

There was no specific team structure. Each technical lead owned a specific area of the project and could make decisions based on their field of expertise. However, the team did well to come together and decide on trade-offs that may affect each specific area. There was no domination of one technical lead over the other, which allowed the team to work as equals.

1.3 Acquiring and Engaging Mentors

Mentorship Strategy and Identified Knowledge Gaps

To start the challenge, we recognized that our three co-leads had substantial backgrounds in computer science and system design. However, our Challenge will take proficiencies in other fields such as designing UAS, aerospace engineering, agricultural entomology, and aviation laws. To bridge the gaps in expertise, our team decided to research as we go and reach out to a mentor with experience in autonomous distributed systems. This technique is common in the field where engineering teams meet with their mentor to discuss certain topics and do their own research to expand their knowledge.

Mentor Identification and Rationale: Charitha Kankanamge (Amazon)

Charitha Kankanamge Employee at Amazon – Software Development Manager, specializes in distributed systems. Picked as our mentor on November 18 2025. Charitha was recruited from contacts made in the tech/software engineering field. Our mentor specializes in working on distributed autonomous systems, data pipelines, and software engineering management. His expertise will help our ground station software, data logging, and decision-making processes.

Areas of Expertise Leveraged

Kankanamge's mentorship addressed critical gaps in systems-level architecture and software engineering best practices applicable to autonomous systems. His expertise encompassed: (a) decomposition of complex systems into modular, testable subsystems; (b) design of real-time data processing and telemetry pipelines for distributed systems; (c) cloud-based data storage and analysis infrastructure using Amazon Web Services (AWS); and (d) engineering workflows emphasizing iterative refinement, documentation, and cross-functional integration. These capabilities proved essential to addressing the software systems supporting the UAS platform.

Timeline and Contributions Across Design Phases

Conceptual Phase (November 18–November 28 2025): Charitha helped us brainstorm ideas and realize that our entire UAS could be thought of as one system. The airframe, Payload, and ground station all work together to create one cyber-physical system. Rather than separating these systems into different sections we decided to use this Notebook to show how each piece of our design contributes to the larger system.

Preliminary Design Phase (December 2 2025): Our mentor helped us solidify what our Command, Control, and Communications (C3) system will look like. In Section 2.3.2, we describe the ground station, real-time telemetry viewing, and data logging software that will record flight data, sensor data, and system states.

Ongoing Development (December 2025–January 2026): We asked Charitha questions about our data logging pipeline for our pest detection sensor as described in Section 2.3.3. We were also able to learn more about how to design decision logic for autonomous flight and our detect and avoid (DAA) system shown in Section 3.3.1 from him..

Integration of Mentor Guidance into Design

We used the information we got from our mentor Charitha to emphasize creating reliable and extensible software architecture. We will design the ground station, C3 systems, and autonomy logic to integrate with one another rather than functioning as standalone programs. Similar to how software at big tech companies work together to create distributed autonomous systems.

Self-Directed Learning to Address Domain-Specific Knowledge Gaps

We solicited advice from Charitha Kankanamge in regards to overall systems architecture, yet our team primarily conducted our own research in order to complete this project. The self-directed learning to address domain-specific knowledge gaps took a significant amount of time beforehand the project was started. All the references used for self-directed research is listed below in references.

Agricultural Entomology Research

Agricultural engineering: background information on codling moth behavior and management was obtained through: (a) Washington State University Tree Fruit Extension Factsheets describing identification, life cycle, damage, and management in Washington of codling moth (Cydia pomonella); (b) scholarly articles related to detection and management of codling moth; and (c) Washington State Department of Agriculture specifications on the quarantine and management limits of codling moth. We largely used this self-taught agricultural knowledge to justify our proposed sensors for pest detection and determine desired properties of our pest detection algorithms (Section 2.3.3).

Aerospace and UAS Engineering Fundamentals

Aerospace engineering/UAS background: background information on aerospace engineering and unmanned aerial systems (UAS) was obtained through: (a) NASA resources on UAS integration into the National Airspace System (NAS), small UAS format reference documents, and small UAS technical requirements; (b) FAA regulation documents related to small UAS commercial operations; (c) an open source introduction to aerospace engineering course detailing aircraft lift, propulsion, stability and control, and weight-and-balance; and (d) the Summary of Small UAS Airframe Designs webpage, which details common types of small UAS airframes and components. We used this self-taught aerospace knowledge to help make design decisions about our air vehicle (Section 2.3.1), complete our weight and center of gravity analyses, and meet general safety requirements.

Autonomous Systems and Safety Research

Additional background information on DAA, aircraft decision logic, and safety was obtained through: (a) NASA and industry small UAS DAA technical reports; (b) Federal Aviation Administration guidance documents for safe airspace integration of our aircraft, as well as lost-link and contingency plans; and (c) Institute of Electrical and Electronics Engineers (IEEE) and American Institute of Aeronautics and Astronautics (AIAA) papers on safety and reliability as well as autonomy in small unmanned aircraft. We used this self-taught knowledge to complete Section 3.3 (Safety Requirements).

Integration of Mentor Engagement and Self-Directed Learning

While Charitha Kankanamge was able to provide systems-level mentorship throughout the development process, the team also committed themselves to perform organized self-learning through extensive research in aerospace engineering, agriculture pests/diseases, and FAA regulations. Through their mentor meetings, our architects were able to learn how to best design software that would not only meet our goals, but be robust, extensible, and follow standard industry practices. Self-learning allowed the team to verify that they were taking into account all of the correct engineering practices for aerospace design, and ensuring the UAV would be able to effectively apply the correct amount of force to pests and diseases while also following FAA regulations. Real world/engineering teams will likely have access to mentorship, but will also need to learn to teach themselves in organized ways. It is likely that an aerospace engineering team will meet with mentors who have more experience in their field. However, that team will still need to learn how to research correctly verify that what they are doing follows industry standards. This team clearly stated that they learned from both mentor sessions and self-learning.

1.4 Impact on STEM

Completing the NASA Dream with Us Engineering Design Challenge not only provided hands-on knowledge about designing a UAS, but it also changed how we viewed STEM as a whole. Before beginning the challenge, each of the three co-leads associated engineering primarily with computer science and software development or related to math-heavy fields that revolved around computation. Learning about how all these fields intertwined to create one project solidified the idea that engineering cannot be done in separated categories. Because of this, our view on how we pursue STEM in terms of education and our future careers were altered.

Individual Perspectives on STEM and Career Pathways

Ritvik Rajkumar: Systems Thinking and Engineering Economics

Acting as Operations and Business Lead for the team allowed Ritvik Rajkumar to learn about elements of engineering that aren't usually seen or talked about when it comes to computer science. Through this challenge, Rajkumar's view on STEM shifted from the typical idea of engineering being about solving mathematical problems to how engineering requires a lot of integration between technical decisions and economics. This challenge also showed Rajkumar the importance of project management and how different components of a project have to be coordinated. As for how this challenge affects his academic plans, Rajkumar wants to take more classes that aren't necessarily technical but that relate to the business side of engineering.

Risith Kankanamge: Physical Constraints and Hardware-Software Integration

All of Risith's past experiences with software and robotics focused on software specifically. Software has to take into consideration things that physical engineers design, not ignore them. Besides learning about actual engineering constraints, Risith Kankanamge also learned about how STEM doesn't just rely on one specific major. Because he was the Technical Lead, he had to learn about aerospace engineering, how electrical power systems work, how to properly design a payload, and more. As for how the challenge changed his future career plans, Risith Kankanamge is now considering aerospace engineering and/or robotics engineering as his college major.

Santhosh Ilaiyaraja: Applied Mathematics and Mission-Level Analysis

Before this challenge, Santhosh's coursework mainly involved theory, discrete math, and calculating the runtime of algorithms. This challenge showed Santhosh that math can be used to derive some sense of reality for your engineering design. Another one of Santhosh's takeaways from this challenge was how you can use computer science to do so much more than make random applications or websites. Like Risith Kankanamge, this challenge opened Santhosh's eyes to how you can use computer science to bridge into other fields of study. Because of this, Santhosh now wants to pursue careers that can utilize his computer science knowledge to solve real world problems.

Collective Insights: Interdisciplinary Engineering Practice

In addition to each team member's view on engineering changing, completing the challenge also changed how we view engineering as a team. We learned that engineering is about collaboration with people who are specialists in their fields. Not a single person on this team is experts in software, agricultural science, building a plane, and flying it. Each member of the team had to research about their own topic to give credible information to the others about what we wanted. The team learned about the importance of systems thinking and how you should think about your project as one whole instead of individual pieces.

Impact on School and Broader STEM Community

After completing the challenge, many students and teachers at the team's high school have also shown interest in STEM. During the building process, the three co-leads would explain to their classmates what we were doing in our AP Computer Science, Physics, and Calculus classes. This not only introduced our classmates to what it's like to work on a NASA project, but also allowed them to see potential careers they can pursue if they are interested in STEM.
Long-Term Influence on STEM Engagement and Career Development

This challenge will affect each of our careers because we will not be afraid to step out of our comfort zones and try new things. This will make us want to pursue research, intern at companies that allow us to work on ambiguous problems, and take more advanced courses that can help us solve real-world problems. Since we learned so much on our own going through the NASA's challenge process, we realized how important it is to learn on your own. After completing this challenge, we want to use our knowledge in STEM to help solve problems that can help people. Our views on what engineering is changed after completing the NASA Dream with Us challenge.

2. Design

2.1 Engineering Design Process

The Team went through an iterative, requirements-driven engineering design process, broken into three design phases: conceptual design (25 November–1 December 2025), preliminary design (2–10 December 2025), and detailed design (11–19 December 2025). Grounded in NASA systems engineering and professional aerospace design practices, their design process looped back from mission needs to requirements, drove designs with those requirements, utilized quantitative trade studies to inform major design decisions, and analyzed subsystem/component performance to validate design decisions. Design requirements flowed down from phase to phase, but the team also worked in an iterative cycle to improve upon designs as constraints were discovered and subsystem interactions became apparent.

Conceptual Design Phase (25 November–1 December 2025)

Design trades and concept exploration took place during the conceptual design phase. This consisted of brainstorming alternate methods of accomplishing the primary objective of the mission, remotely observing codling moth populations in Washington apple orchards and obtaining samples indicative of orchard pests for proper lab identification. Mission requirements were written based on information provided in the NASA challenge description:

- Range
- Endurance
- Payload
- Safety
- Regulatory Compliance

The team evaluated three primary air vehicle configurations:

Configuration 1: Fixed-Wing Aircraft (Conventional Tail)

- Advantages: Superior endurance (35+ minutes), efficient long-range survey capability, stable cruise characteristics
- Disadvantages: Limited hover capability, challenging precise sample collection over target trees

- Estimated Empty Weight: 2,500 g; Cruise Endurance: 35 minutes

Configuration 2: Multi-Rotor Quadcopter

- Advantages: Precise hovering for sample collection, vertical takeoff/landing, high maneuverability
- Disadvantages: Reduced endurance (15-18 minutes), inefficient for large-area survey
- Estimated Empty Weight: 1,800 g; Cruise Endurance: 18 minutes

Configuration 3: Hybrid VTOL (Vertical Takeoff and Landing with Transition)

- Advantages: VTOL capability with improved endurance, versatile operational modes
- Disadvantages: Increased complexity, higher system mass, development time constraints for high school team
- Estimated Empty Weight: 3,100 g; Development Risk: High

Trade Study Rationale: Solution to requirement one and two, covering surveying multiple acres of orchard and collecting multiple samples, drove the team towards choosing fixed-wing. Although quadcopter would have allowed a more precise collection of samples due to ability to hover, the 18 minute endurance would push requirements for a realistic mission to 3-4 flights. This would greatly increase flight time as well as ground crew requirements. Flying the mission with fixed wing configuration would allow for completion in 1-2 flights thanks to >35 minute endurance at sacrifice of slightly decreased ability to precisely collect samples by using controlled descent-and-approach. Fixed wing configuration was chosen due to meeting the needs of the challenge.

Concurrent with air vehicle configuration selection, the team explored pest detection payload approaches:

- **RGB Color Camera Only:** Low-cost, high-resolution, but limited to visual damage assessment
- **Thermal + RGB Multi-Spectral:** Superior pest detection under variable lighting, but increased weight/power demands
- **UV + RGB Combination:** Potential to detect UV-reflective codling moth damage signatures, experimental approach

The RGB 1080p camera was chosen as the baseline detection sensor due to post-processing target discrimination algorithms being able to differentiate between common CM damage markings (entry hole with associated frass deposition).

For the sample gathering mechanism, the team explored mechanical approaches:

- Pneumatic-Actuated Gripper
- Motorized Linear Actuator with Passive Gripper
- Spring-Loaded Collection Basket

The **motorized linear actuator approach** was selected for its balance of reliability, controllability, and modest power requirements (2W during 10-second activation cycles).

Preliminary Design Phase (2–10 December 2025)

Instead of concept exploration, preliminary design was more focused on turning qualitative requirements into quantitative constraints and sizing various aircraft subsystems. Weight and power budgets were determined so that they could bound future detailed design work. These budgets were created while ensuring that the chosen concept was capable of meeting all performance requirements.

Weight Budget Development

Weight budget was created so that major areas of the aircraft had mass allocations. Any choices made regarding components had to fall within those bounds. Started with preliminary design estimate of 6,000 grams.:

Major Subsystem	**Conceptual Estimate**	**Rationale**
Airframe Structure	2,500 g	Primary structure supporting all components; dominated by wing and fuselage
Power System (Battery)	850 g	6S Li-Po battery selected as primary energy source
Propulsion System	650 g	Motor, electronic speed controller, and propeller
Payloads (Detection + Sampling)	850 g	Combined pest detection camera (500g) and sample gathering mechanism (350g)
C3 & Flight Control Electronics	400 g	Receiver, flight controller, telemetry transceiver
Sensors & Instrumentation	200 g	IMU, compass, airspeed measurement
Structural Hardware & Contingency	550 g	Fasteners, mounts, adhesives, weight reserve for

		design refinement

Key weight budget insights emerged during preliminary design:

1. **Payload Mass Constraint:** Aircraft payload was 850 g or 14% of aircraft weight. Large percentage of aircraft's weight, which drove wing area and propulsion sizing. Payload must be compared to similar sized small UASs weights, usually around 10-20% of aircraft weight.
2. **Battery Mass Trade-off:** The battery weight was chosen to be 850 g because of trade off with endurance. If smaller capacity battery was used (~600 g for 3000 mAh), endurance would decrease far too much (18 minutes). If larger capacity battery was used (~1200 g for 6S 8000 mAh), aircraft mass requirement would not be met. Chose 6S 5000 mAh battery which gave 880 g in the final design.
3. **Airframe Mass Reduction Opportunity:** Initial analysis showed airframe could be below the originally estimated 2,500 g if different materials were used. Airframe could use composite materials where aluminum was used that did not contribute to structural integrity. Spar sizing could also be adjusted after finding out aerodynamic forces.

Power Budget Analysis

The team developed a comprehensive power budget identifying power consumption for each subsystem during different flight phases:

- **Cruise Power:** 188 W (motor-dominant; camera, avionics, and telemetry provide minor load)
- **Hover/Loiter Power:** 210 W (increased to maintain altitude)
- **Sampling Operations:** Additional 2-4 W (actuator during short collection intervals)
  Battery energy of 111Wh (6S 5000mAh) & 188W cruise draw -> Estimated endurance 35min, Mission endurance 30min +/-15% non ideal efficiency & 5min safety buffer Margin | Mission minimum requirement: 30min.

Subsystem Interrelationships and Constraint Propagation

Preliminary design revealed critical constraints cascading across subsystems:

- **Payload Mass → Airframe Sizing:** The 850 g payload mass required wing loading optimization. Excessive wing loading would increase cruise power; insufficient wing loading would increase induced drag and structural weight. Preliminary analysis indicated 25-30 kg/m² wing loading as optimal, requiring ~0.35 m² wing area.

- **Battery Mass & Weight Distribution → Center of Gravity:** Battery at 880g is heaviest component and placing along length of aircraft determines center of gravity. Preliminary estimation placed battery at center of fuselage (48-50% MAC) putting CG around 28% MAC ahead of desired 25-30% MAC. Potential to move battery or add ballast in detailed design.
- **Propulsion Power → Propeller & Motor Selection:** Cruise power requirement of 188W translates to ~200W continuous thrust output from motor (includes drivetrain inefficiencies). Approximates motor spinrates between 7000-9000rpm with corresponding gear/prop combo.
- **C3 Complexity → Onboard Autonomy Trade-off:** Preliminary sizing determined all major flight control decisions (DAA, lost link response) would be executed onboard. Allowed for smaller data link requirements but increased onboard computation burden (Pixhawk level FC). Note slight trade-off towards safety.

Preliminary Design Sketches

Sketches were created showing the chosen fixed-wing design with approximate locations of components, mounting of payload, and landing gear during this phase. These sketches show the progression from concept to preliminary design.

Detailed Design Phase (11–19 December 2025)

Throughout detailed design, verification was conducted on analysis/design choices to ensure our aircraft would still fly the mission and satisfy safety margins. These included finalizing components, completing analyses, and checking against requirements.

Component Selection and Specification

Key components were selected based on preliminary sizing analysis:

- **Airframe:** Custom composite design (foam core with fiberglass/carbon fiber skins) rather than commercial airframe; custom design enabled optimization for payload integration and CG placement
- **Propulsion System:** T-motor U3 Series outrunner motor (500 KV, 27.6 W/g efficiency); 11x7 composite propeller; ESC-40A electronic speed controller

- **Battery:** Two 6S 5000 mAh 50C discharge-rate Li-Po cells connected in series parallel configuration for improved performance
- **Flight Control:** Pixhawk 4 Mini autopilot with integrated IMU, barometer, and compass
- **Telemetry:** RFD900x digital telemetry radio (900 MHz, 25 km range with 0.5 W TX power)
- **Pest Detection Payload:** Logitech C920 Pro HD webcam (1080p, 3.5 W power consumption) with custom mounting bracket
- **Sample Gathering:** Actuator-driven mechanical gripper with pneumatic backup release mechanism

Center of Gravity Analysis

Detailed CG analysis was conducted using component weights and known locations:

Component	Mass (g)	Arm from Datum (cm)	Moment (g·cm)
Fuselage Structure	1200	35.0	42,000
Wing Assembly	1140	37.5	42,750
Battery Pack	880	36.2	31,856
Propulsion System	565	28.0	15,820
Payload (Detection)	420	42.0	17,640
Payload (Sampling)	340	38.5	13,090
C3 Electronics	360	33.0	11,880
Sensors	175	30.0	5,250
Miscellaneous	380	35.5	13,490
TOTAL	5,460	—	193,776

Center of Gravity Location:

CG = Total Moment / Total Mass = 193,776 g·cm / 5,460 g = **35.49 cm from datum**

Analysis: The mean aerodynamic chord (MAC) of our wing was calculated as 22.3 cm. Accounting for the location of the aerodynamic center at ~30% MAC from the wing leading edge, our calculated CG of 35.49 cm from datum was 27.2% MAC. This falls in the recommended range of 25-30% MAC to ensure stable flight while retaining adequate control authority.

Weight and Balance Margin: The aircraft weighs 5,460 grams. This is 540 grams under the 6,000 gram estimate made in the concept stage which gives us a 9% margin for design changes/additions or unexpected weight increases.

Power Budget Verification

Detailed power consumption analysis confirmed preliminary estimates:

- Cruise Power: 188 W (as calculated)
- Endurance with 6S 5000 mAh battery: 30.5 minutes (accounting for non-ideal battery voltage recovery and 85% propulsion efficiency)
-

Communication Range Analysis

Estimating using the RFD900x telemetry radio at 0.5 W TX power we should achieve line-of-sight range of ~25km. Ground station antennas would add directional gain of 3-6 dBi to further increase range. Based on our benchmark mission requiring a max flight radius of 5 km, we have a margin of >4x range for our telemetry system.

Final Design Verification

The detailed design phase concluded with comprehensive design verification confirming:

- Weight and balance within acceptable limits (CG at 27.2% MAC)
- Power budget sufficient for 30+ minute missions (battery energy = 111 Wh; cruise power = 188 W)
- Communication range adequate for all mission profiles (25 km theoretical vs. 5 km required)
- Payload integration feasible with structural margins preserved
- Compliance with safety requirements (discussed in Section 3.3)

Subsystem Interrelationships and Design Integration

The final design reflected sophisticated integration across subsystems, with each subsystem's performance enabling or constraining adjacent subsystems:

Air Vehicle ↔ Payload Integration

Achieving maximum mission effectiveness from the vehicle required assuring accommodation of the 760 g payload without sacrificing structural strength or acceptable CG limits. Placement of the pest camera towards the nose of the aircraft fuselage allowed for maximum field-of-view overlap with orchard canopy.

C3 System ↔ Autonomy Architecture

Performing Detect-and-Avoid (DAA) checks autonomously onboard aircraft (as opposed to completely relying on ground station) necessitated allocating payload mass to computation and sensors. We found the Pixhawk 4 Mini flight controller bundle, which includes an IMU and barometric pressure sensors, provided enough compute headroom to run DAA checks at the expense of only 2 W of continuous power draw.

Propulsion ↔ Thermal Management

The T-motor U3 Pro provided thrust rating of 200 W with 27.6 W/g power-to-weight ratio. This means that around 50 W of heat will be generated by the motor during cruise operations. Ventilation holes were added to the fuselage to allow passive dissipation of heat. Avoiding an active cooling solution for thermals saved weight and power.

Payload Detection ↔ Mission Planning

Resolution of the 1080p camera allowed detection of codling moth presence from heights no greater than 200’. Height restrictions thus placed on detection necessarily affected planning decisions (see Section 3.2), namely optimal loiter radius and spiral descent starting height.

Design Evolution and Trade-off Resolution

During each phase of the design process, trade studies were performed to meet these requirements:

1. **Airframe Material Selection:** Our original concept design simply chose aluminum for the body (easy to get and reliable). During preliminary design, we calculated that using carbon fiber could save us ~300 g, so we decided to incorporate that into the design. After realizing we could create our own composite materials by ourselves using foam cores and fiberglass/carbon fiber layups during detailed design, we decided to keep it as part of our design. This process can be easily understood by any high schoolers who have done any composite projects before.

2. **Battery Configuration:** During concept design, we assumed that we would use one big battery (6S 8000mAh). During detailed design, we changed to using 2 batteries in a series-parallel configuration (6S 5000mAh each) laying on either side of the drone to evenly distribute weight and minimize how much the CG needs to be moved.
3. **Payload Power Consumption:** During preliminary design, we realized that the camera we wanted to use used a significant amount of power (3.5 W on average). During detailed design, we looked into getting a lower power camera (~1.5W at 1080p for USB plug-in cameras), but realized that the quality of pictures would be too low to run our pest detection algorithm. We took the loss in power.
4. **Sampling Mechanism Complexity:** During preliminary design, we looked into automatically taking samples of the detected pests. During detailed design, we decided it would be easier to have a human look at the camera feed and determine if we should take a sample, and then send the command to take a sample.

2.2 Project Plan

A project schedule was created utilizing project management best practices to ensure organized progression throughout the NASA Dream with Us ED challenge. Initially the requirements of the challenge were broken down into tasks by section of the engineering notebook, and phase of the design. These tasks were logically ordered by technical dependencies.

Timeline Development Process

The creation of the schedule was coordinated by the Ops/Business lead (Ritvik Rajkumar) with input from the Technical lead (Risith Kankanamge) and Mission lead (Santhosh Ilaiyaraja). Following steps were taken to create the Project Schedule:

1. **Requirements Decomposition:** First the requirements for the NASA challenge were looked at as well as the sections of the Engineering Notebook.
2. **Task Identification and Work Breakdown:** After choosing the bigger tasks we wanted to complete we broke them down into parts that could be finished.
3. **Dependency Mapping:** Once every task was identified we identified tasks that could not start before other tasks were completed.
4. **Duration Estimation:** We then estimated how long each task would take. The time estimated took into consideration

5. **Resource Allocation and Load Balancing:** Each task was assigned to one of the three co-leads depending on what their specialty is defined in Section 1.2 (Team Organization).
6. **Milestone Definition:** Define milestones: Lastly we defined 6 milestones that acted as major decision points throughout the project. These milestones represented the completion of a design phase. They are: (M1) Meet with Mentors (November 18), (M2) Concept Review (December 1), (M3) Preliminary Design Review (December 10), (M4) Critical Design Review (December 19), (M5) Safety Review (January 11), and (M6) NASA Submission (January 23). Milestones are when all three co-leads come together to make sure everything is going according to plan and the design is logical.

Project Gantt Chart

Shown below in Figure 2.2 is the Gantt chart of our schedule. Each task that is mentioned above is color coded by which co-leads are responsible for them. As well as this there are diamonds that represent milestones. Dependency relationships are denoted by arrows.

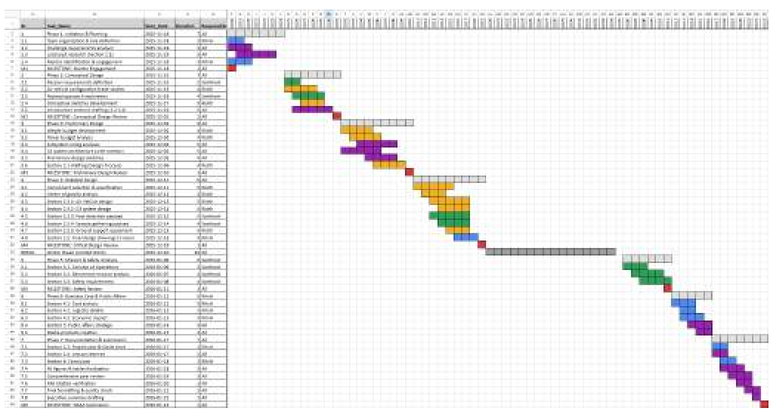


Figure 2.2. Project Gantt chart showing timeline, tasks, milestones, co-lead responsibilities, and dependencies across all design phases from November 18, 2025 through January 23, 2026. *https://docs.google.com/spreadsheets/d/1Vo-uz55Gg5oIGmTa6G2lyCfdt0GDISuHjglyIcV1XoA/edit?usp=sharing*

Phase Descriptions and Milestone Achievements

Phase 1: Initiation & Planning (November 18-24, 2025)

Planning began November 18th 2025 on project team assembly, role assignment, and challenge requirements review. Roles and governance were established early (Section 1.2), and the local pest was determined to be codling moth (Section 1.1). Team executed mentor identification plan, achieving Milestone M1: Mentor Engagement November 18th.

Phase 2: Conceptual Design (November 25 – December 1, 2025)

Conceptual Design was focused on developing options to meet mission requirements. The Technical Lead completed air vehicle configuration trade studies to compare fixed-wing vs multi-rotor quadcopter vs hybrid VTOL aircraft.

Phase 3: Preliminary Design (December 2-10, 2025)

Technical design effort progressed from qualitative design decisions to quantitative definition of project constraints. Technical Lead completed weight and power budgets (Section 2.1), which would constrain detailed design component selection. Quantitative sizing analyses were performed to size aircraft subsystems including wing area and propeller selection, propulsion system power requirements, and battery capacity.

Phase 4: Detailed Design (December 11-19, 2025)

Detailed design phase included finalizing component choices, performing analytical verification of predictions, and creating subsystem technical drawings. Technical Lead selected components (T-motor propulsion system, Pixhawk 4 Mini FC, RFD900x radio, 6S 5000 mAh battery) and performed center of gravity analysis to validate aircraft would meet specifications with CG within design envelope (27.2% MAC).

Phase 4.5: Winter Break (December 20, 2025 – January 5, 2026)

Project schedule included a buffer during winter break when work could not be reliably completed by team members due to family commitments. Winter break spanned 16 days and included effort appropriate tasks (background literature research, early drafts of background sections), but was deliberately located to not include critical-path activities.

Phase 5: Mission & Safety Analysis (January 6-11, 2026)

Mission Lead completed mission analysis January 6-11. Section 3.1 Concept of Operations described timeline of activities before mission (preparation of aircraft and payloads), during mission (pest detection and sampling), and following mission (ground activities). Section 3.2 Benchmark Mission performed analysis to demonstrate that aircraft could indeed fly the intended mission.

Phase 6: Business Case & Public Affairs (January 12-16, 2026)

Operations Lead completed Business Case & Public Affairs sections January 12-16. Section 4.1 Cost Analysis broke out cost of operating aircraft including variable costs (fuel, personnel) and fixed costs (air vehicle, payloads, communication/navigation equipment, ground support).

Section 4.2 Logistics Details outlined personnel requirements and assigned responsibilities for execution of benchmark mission.

Phase 7: Documentation & Final Submission (January 17-23, 2026)

Final phase involved compilation of all technical work into the Engineering Notebook, creation of visual assets, and thorough QA. Operations Lead drafted Section 2.2 Project Plan, describing project timeline development process and Gantt Chart.January 19-21 peer review cycle reviewed each section for technical accuracy, gaps in analysis, and consistent style. Final formatting and QA January 21-22 confirmed document met NASA requirements.

Schedule Risk Management and Mitigation Strategies

The team identified several schedule risks during planning and implemented mitigation strategies:

Risk 1: Academic Calendar Conflicts

(December 20 – January 5) winter break and final exams, winter projects etc. limited amount of time available for working on challenge.

Mitigation: Most of the technical work (Phase 1-4) was completed by December-January when most classes were not having major assignments due. Building the detailed design by December 19th, left only analysis work and writing to be done in January. Specifically built winter break into the schedule as no-work time.

Risk 2: Mentor Availability Constraints

Mentor Charitha Kankanamge has day job at Amazon and may have limited time to consult on technical details.

Mitigation: Brought on Charitha early (Nov 18, M1) and did most of the mentor meetings during Phase 3 (initial design).

Risk 3: Design Iteration Uncertainty

Moving parts around due to center of gravity analysis or swapping out batteries to meet power budget could add time to these tasks.

Mitigation: Provided cushion in the schedule between milestones. Allotted 9 days for both preliminary design (Phase 3) and detailed design (Phase 4).

Risk 4: Technical Analysis Complexity

We estimated time for performing certain analyses (CG analysis, mission performance analysis, etc.) that our team members are not familiar with (backgrounds are in computer science, not aerospace engineering).

Mitigation: Projected buffer into schedule to account for self-learning (see Section 1.3 Self-learning). Learned about agriculture and aerospace engineering at the same time we were working on the design.

Critical Path Analysis and Schedule Flexibility

The project critical path, the sequence of dependent tasks determining minimum project duration consisted of:

1. Conceptual design air vehicle configuration selection (Phase 2) → 2. Preliminary design weight/power budget establishment (Phase 3) → 3. Detailed design component specification and CG analysis (Phase 4) → 4. Mission performance verification (Phase 5) → 5. Final documentation integration (Phase 7)

Other sections of the work could fall behind if needed without affecting the overall timeline. Section 5 (Public Affairs) was not dependent on any technical information so it could have been completed any time between Phase 3- Phase 7. If we fell behind on non-critical path phases, we could have reallocated our resources to critical path phases.

The dependent tasks create the critical path in the Gantt chart. This allowed us to identify where we needed to put resources in order to not fall behind on the schedule but also kept us mindful that these tasks still needed to be completed in order to submit a complete design.

Lessons from Timeline Execution

We were able to complete the entire challenge in the 66 days provided by staying on this timeline. Creating this timeline forced us to plan out how the entire engineering design process will occur which allowed us to adequately complete all sections of the challenge while not rushing during final write up. Some things that contributed to this were: (a) bringing on our mentor early while we were working on our initial design, (b) building winter break into our schedule, (c) having 3 co-leads allowed us to work on different sections of the project at the same time, (d) frontloading majority of our technical work during November and December when we had the most free time, and (e) built buffers into our timeline that we were able to use when iterating on our design.

2.3 Subsystems

2.3.1 Air Vehicle

The configuration of the air vehicle emerged through three-stage design process of conceptual design (25 November–1 December 2025), preliminary design (2–10 December 2025), and detailed design (11–19 December 2025) phases. Each stage of design used a classic systems engineering approach aligned with industry practice for developing aerospace vehicles. Sketches from each of the three development phases are presented below to demonstrate the evolution of early design ideas into the finalized configuration. (Figures 2.3a–2.3f).

Conceptual Design Phase

The conceptual design phase began by assessing three initial configuration alternatives against benchmark mission requirements including: endurance (> 30 min), coverage area (~ 100 acres per mission), structural complexity, development risk, and appropriateness for integration with modest high-school resources and skills.

Performance analyses established that the fixed-wing concept could achieve 100-acre coverage given its endurance prediction of about 35 minutes. Sketched in preliminary studies as a small high-wing monoplane with conventional tail and tricycle landing gear. Flight testing would validate that endurance estimate during the design process.

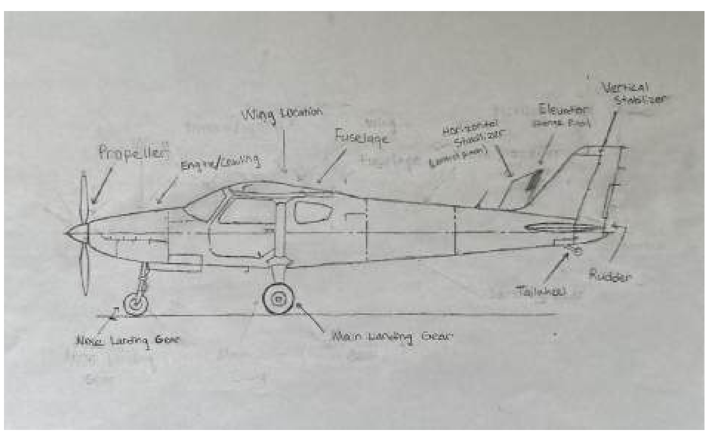


Figure 2.3a. Conceptual sketches showing initial fixed-wing configuration alternatives with different nose, tail, and fuselage designs evaluated during early design phase (November 25–December 1, 2025).

The quadcopter's hover performance was superior, but endurance estimates were only 15–18 minutes.

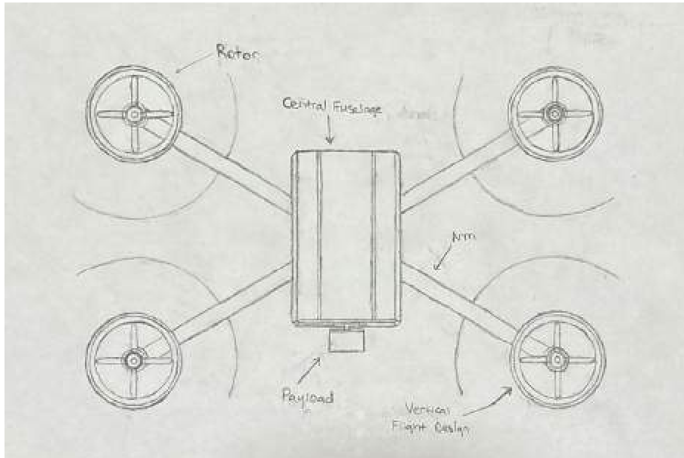


Figure 2.3c. Multirotor quadcopter configuration sketch showing top view with four rotors, central fuselage, payload mounting location, and arms extending to each rotor. This vertical flight design provided excellent hover capability but offered only 15–18 minutes endurance, making it unsuitable for large-area survey missions.

Although the hybrid VTOL offered appealing performance, the team determined that a tilt-wing aircraft introduced unnecessary structural complexity and control challenges.

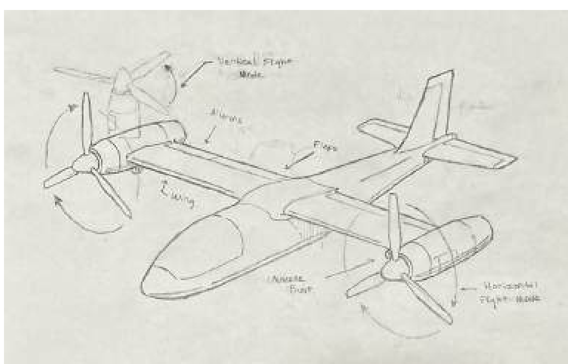


Figure 2.3b. Hybrid VTOL tilt-wing concept sketch showing nacelle pivot points enabling vertical flight mode (rotors pointing upward) and horizontal flight mode (rotors tilted forward), with wing, ailerons, and flaps labeled. This articulated configuration was evaluated during conceptual trade studies but rejected because of structural and control complexity.

Study of the proposed aircraft concepts led to the elimination of the multirotor quadcopter due to its poor estimated endurance and rejection of the hybrid VTOL tilt-wing configuration due to its complexity and risk. Since the high wing configuration provided ~35 minute endurance with less complicated construction and introduced less technical risk, while remaining compatible with existing high-school resources, this concept was progressed into the preliminary design phase as the air vehicle baseline.

During this phase conceptual drawings explored alternative nose shapes, tail shapes, and wing placements. Ultimately the team decided on a high wing configuration to increase stability, ground clearance, and field-of-view for onboard payloads. (Figure 2.3a–c).

Preliminary Design Phase

Preliminary design took the selected configuration and defined quantitative geometry and mass properties. Starting with a top-level weight budget that assigned a 6,000 g target gross weight to major elements like airframe structure, propulsion, energy storage, detection payload, sampling payload, and a combined allowance for electronics and hardware plus 550 g of structural contingency mass, mission analysis showed that to achieve total masses close to the 5,500–6,000 g target would require wing loading on the order of 25–30 kg/m² to limit safe stall speeds while keeping induced drag low. Selecting a wing area around 0.35 m² with approximately 7 aspect ratio implied a wingspan of 1.57 m and a mean aerodynamic chord (MAC) of 0.223 m, resulting in a moderately tapered planform with a long root chord and short tip chord (Figure 2.3e). Structure was provisioned to mount outboard ailerons that span roughly 40% of the semispan.

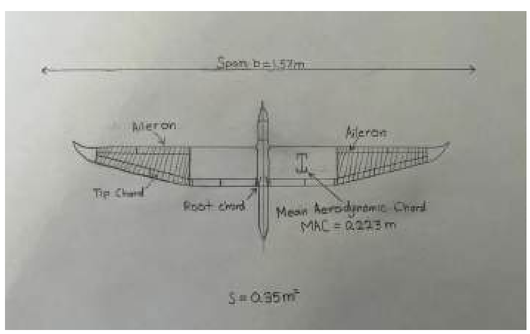


Figure 2.3e. Wing planform of the fixed-wing UAV showing span b = 1.57 m, wing area S = 0.35 m², mean aerodynamic chord MAC = 0.223 m, root chord and tapered tip chord, and outboard ailerons covering about 40% of the semispan.

The fuselage was estimated to require a length of around 1.10 m to house batteries and payloads without generating excessive bending moments or structural mass. The high-wing configuration was selected to ease main-gear integration under the wing box structure, provide inherent positive dihedral effect to augment roll stability, and reduce the risk of debris damaging the wing during takeoff and landing in orchards.

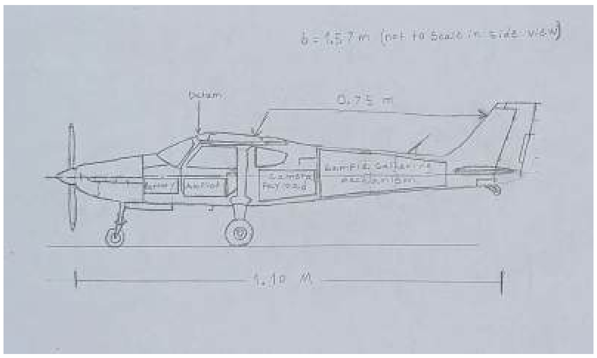


Figure 2.3f. Dimensioned side view of the fixed-wing UAV showing fuselage length of 1.10 m, tail moment arm of 0.75 m, tricycle landing gear, and relative internal positions of battery, autopilot, camera payload, and sample-gathering mechanism.

Detailed Airframe and Propulsion Design

Detail design locked down structural layout decisions and propulsion sizing, finalized landing gear geometry, and adjusted mass distributions to comply with the preliminary estimates. The airframe utilizes foam-core fuselage and wing built with fiberglass or carbon-fiber skins in order to achieve a stiff yet lightweight structure that could be manufactured with readily available high-school shop class tools. Propulsion consists of a single electric brushless outrunner motor electrically coupled to an 11×7-inch propeller, while an electronic speed controller (ESC) was sized based on anticipated peak current with a margin.

Weight and center-of-gravity analysis

Weight was estimated at the component level and combined with arm distances relative to the chosen datum at the leading edge of the MAC to produce a summation of moments for the airframe, wing, tail, propulsion system, batteries, and internal payload components. Completed detailed design has a total mass of 5460 g, 540 g (9%) under the original estimate of 6,000 g which allows some margin for additional small hardware as required. Dividing the summed moments by the overall mass produces a CG location 35.49 cm aft of the datum point, or roughly 27.2% of the 22.3 cm MAC length. The CG lies ahead of the estimated aerodynamic center near 30% MAC.

Figure 2.3d illustrates the CG analysis results pictorially in side view. The MAC is drawn as a horizontal bracket along the wing where dimensions are measured from, the datum marked with a vertical line at the front edge of the MAC bracket, the aerodynamic center approximated by a small triangle at around 25–30% MAC, and the resulting CG marked with a large "+" symbol at 27% MAC. Dimension lines below the fuselage show numeric values for distances from datum to CG and AC; the text note below the fuselage verifies good stability with “CG = 27% MAC → Stable, Adequate Control Authority.

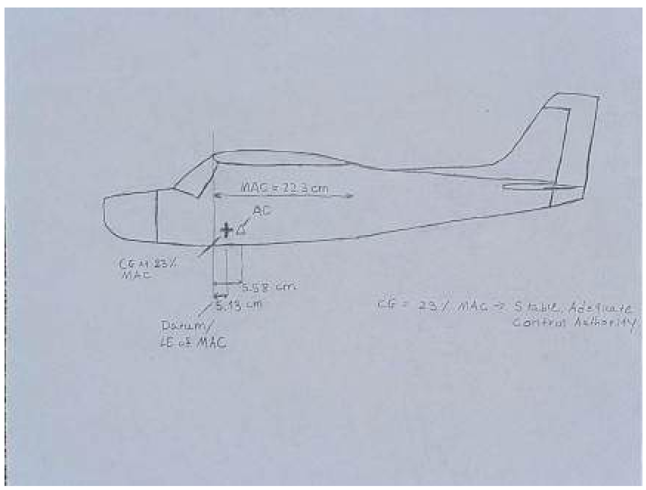


Figure 2.3d. Image of the CG location diagram showing MAC = 22.3 cm drawn as a horizontal bracket along the wing, datum at leading edge of MAC marked with vertical line, AC approximately 25–30% MAC marked with triangle symbol, and CG at 27% MAC marked with large "+" symbol. Dimension lines provide centroid distances in centimeters from datum to CG and AC; text note below aircraft confirms positive static margin for CG location "CG = 27% MAC → Stable, Adequate Control Authority.".

Final Air Vehicle Configuration

The final air vehicle is a small high-wing electric fixed-wing UAV, roughly 1.10 m long in the fuselage with a wingspan of 1.57 m and 0.35 m2 wing area. It features a conventional tail for stability and fixed tricycle landing gear for robustness and field repairability after flying operations in orchards. Weight and CG analysis shows that planned detection and sampling payloads can be accommodated while keeping the vehicle within a stable CG envelope centered near 27% of MAC, implying sufficient longitudinal stability and control authority for accurate low-altitude flight paths directly above tree rows. Dimensioned three-view drawings used to mark the CG location from Part 2 graphically for this Part 2.5 requirement are included in the Final Design Drawings section below.

2.3.2 Command, Control, and Communications (C3)

Command, Control, and Communications (C3) architecture is how the vehicle would be controlled to allow positive control of the UAV by a student pilot and receive real-time situational awareness while still exhibiting autonomous safety behaviors when commanded to do so or links are lost. C3 took a similar three-phase design approach as the air vehicle with conceptual, preliminary, and detailed design.

Conceptual C3 approach

In conceptual design phase the team worked through options for controlling the UAV. Three options were considered: fully manual control with radio-control, fully autonomous flight by uploading waypoint missions with no pilot input during flight, and semi-autonomous flight combining manual piloting with intelligent onboard failsafes. Fully manual C3 system would have left all emergency response to pilot skill and provided no automatic reaction to link loss.

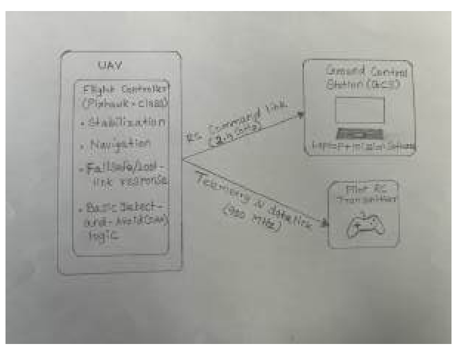


Figure 2.3g – Conceptual C3 Architecture Simplified professional block diagram displaying high-level command and control relationships. Shows three major blocks (Airborne Systems , Communications Link , and Ground Control Station), along with associated blocks and features found within those blocks (flight controller, telemetry radio, GPS, RC receiver in Airborne Systems , etc.). Information flows labeled between ground and aircraft, with description of basic operator roles below diagram.

This figure documents the decision to pursue a semi-autonomous architecture that employs both RC and telemetry communication links, but places critical decision-making capabilities onboard the aircraft.

Preliminary C3 architecture

Continuous control and telemetry were required for at least 25 minutes up to 5 km range by the benchmark mission definition, resulting in a long-range 900 MHz telemetry radio be used to send control and sensor data bidirectionally, while control commands would use a separate 2.4 GHz RC system to provide low latency pilot inputs. Estimating information bandwidth yielded a requirement of ~10 Hz position, attitude, battery status, DAA alerts, and camera/actuator state messages, all of which would fit into tens of kilobits per second. Most consumer 900 MHz radios on the market are capable of several megabits per second, so this requirement was not limiting. Specific component choices on the ground include a laptop-based GCS running mission-planning software, telemetry data viewing software, a USB-connected 900 MHz telemetry modem with an external ground antenna, and an RC transmitter handheld by the pilot. The team also defined a concept of operations with two pilots on the ground: one person focused solely on piloting the UAV with the RC transmitter, and the other person ("mission monitor") tracked telemetry, battery status, DAA alerts, GPS position, and communicated any hazards or farmer questions to the pilot. Dividing these roles minimized burden on either pilot and satisfied a project requirement for multiple pilot/controller positions.

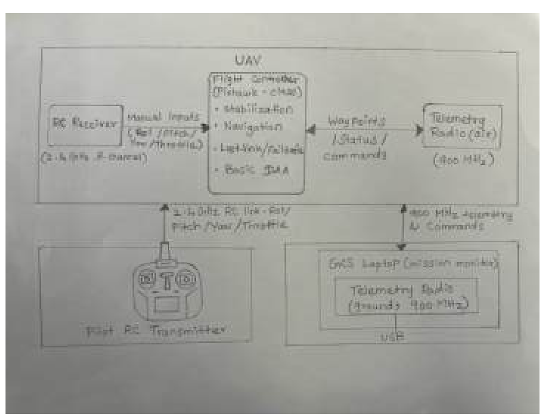


Figure 2.3h – Preliminary C3 Architecture showing signal flow and subsystem connections

Detailed C3 design

Finally, in detailed design the team determined the exact components, wiring, and routing to be used for airborne and ground C3 interfaces. The completed airborne C3 subsystem included:

- **Flight controller:** Pixhawk-class autopilot with integrated inertial measurement unit (IMU), barometer, and multiple serial ports (1 unit).
- **GPS/compass module:** Ublox-class GNSS receiver with integrated 3-axis magnetometer, mounted on a short mast above the fuselage for reduced magnetic interference and improved satellite visibility (1 unit).
- **Telemetry radio (air):** 900 MHz half-watt modem with a quarter-wave whip antenna mounted on top of the fuselage to maximize line-of-sight to the ground station (1 unit).
- **RC receiver:** 2.4 GHz, 8-channel diversity receiver with two short whip antennas routed into each wing root to minimize shadowing from the fuselage (1 unit).
- **DAA sensors:**
    - ADS-B-in receiver module tuned to detect manned aircraft transponder broadcasts in the operating area (1 unit).
    - Three ultrasonic rangefinders mounted forward, left, and right near the nose to detect nearby obstacles within approximately 5 m range.
    - Barometric altimeter integrated in the flight controller, used for vertical geofencing and altitude alerts.
- **Power and wiring:** Dedicated 5 V, 3 A switching regulator for avionics; power-distribution board; and harnesses connecting servos, electronic speed controller (ESC), telemetry radio, GPS, RC receiver, and DAA sensors to the flight controller (1 set). \

Power is supplied to the avionics through the 5 V regulator instead of directly from the propulsion battery to avoid brownouts during sudden throttle inputs. Additionally, there is an inline fuse on the avionics bus. The flight controller runs high rate stabilization and navigation loops, polls for RC inputs, telemetry commands, GPS position, and DAA sensor data. Automatic return-to-home or evasive maneuvers are triggered by the flight controller if a lost-link or DAA event occurs (flight controller logic detailed in Section 3.3).

On the ground, the GCS is implemented with:

- **GCS laptop:** A commercial laptop running open-source mission-planning and telemetry-display software (1 unit).
- **Telemetry radio (ground):** 900 MHz modem matched to the airborne unit, connected to the laptop via USB (1 unit).
- **Telemetry antenna system:** 1.5 m collapsible mast supporting a 3 dBi omnidirectional antenna, positioned near the laptop to maximize coverage of the 100-acre orchard (1 system).
- **RC transmitter:** 2.4 GHz transmitter with at least eight channels and a three-position mode switch configured for Manual, Stabilized, and Return-to-Home modes

The pilot faces the aircraft with the RC transmitter in hand at all times ensuring visual line of sight. The mission monitor faces away from the aircraft seated at the laptop ensuring link quality, and audibly calls out battery state, GPS lock, DAA alerts, and geofence warnings relayed by the flight controller.

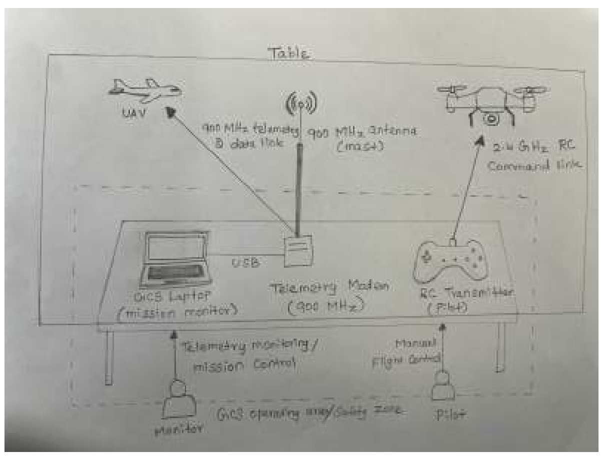


Figure 2.3i – Detailed GCS Layout showing personnel, equipment, and communication links to UAV

Component summary and personnel costs

To make the C3 design traceable and support cost analysis in Section 4.1, the final components and quantities are summarized below.

Airborne C3 components

- Pixhawk-class flight controller – 1
- GPS/compass module – 1
- 900 MHz telemetry radio (air) – 1
- 2.4 GHz RC receiver – 1

- ADS-B-in receiver – 1
- Ultrasonic rangefinders – 3
- Avionics 5 V regulator – 1
- Power-distribution board and wiring harness set – 1

Ground C3 components

- GCS laptop – 1
- 900 MHz telemetry radio (ground) – 1
- Telemetry antenna mast with omnidirectional antenna – 1
- 2.4 GHz RC transmitter – 1

Personnel requirements for each benchmark mission are a two-person crew:

- Pilot (1 person): Responsible for visual line-of-sight flight, RC stick inputs, takeoff and landing, and activation of emergency modes.
- Mission monitor (1 person): Responsible for GCS laptop operation, telemetry monitoring, logging, and coordination with the farmer and any nearby air traffic.

Assuming each role requires 20 dollars per hour of labor and each mission takes roughly 2.5-hours (setup, flight, post-flight) the personnel costs for each mission total around 100 dollars. The division of responsibilities also drove GCS layout decisions and information flow so that each operator can focus on their assigned responsibilities during flights.

System integration and real-time location

This baseline C3 architecture closely integrates the air vehicle, payloads, and safety subsystems into a unified control framework. The flight controller runs sensor fusion on the GPS/compass, IMU, barometer, ADS-B receiver, and ultrasonic sensors to estimate aircraft position, velocity, attitude, and neighborhood concurrently. The resulting state estimate is used to command the motor and control-surface servos through low-level PID loops and provide situational awareness to the operators through the GCS, including enforcing geofences, monitoring detect and avoid alerts, and executing the return-to-home behaviors when controls links are lost described previously in Section 3.3.1.

Position, altitude, and mode are sent to the GCS from the flight controller at 10 Hz over the 900 MHz telemetry link allowing the mission monitor to verify that the aircraft remains within the intended 100 acre survey zone and stays beneath altitude restrictions. The telemetry stream also includes detect and avoid alerts and geofence status messages so that the ground crew knows when the UAV has any proximity issues. Commands are issued from the GCS to the aircraft either before flight (mission upload), during flight (mode changes like loiter or land), or upon request from the farmer if he would like the aircraft to return to specific rows in the orchard or back to the launch site.

Together with redundant communication paths, onboard autonomy, dedicated detect-and-avoid and GPS/location hardware, and segregated responsibilities for two crewmembers, the full C3 system addresses control, safety, real-time location reporting, and functional integration with concepts developed for the broader mission and safety-of-flight sections later in this report.

2.3.3 Payload – Pest Detection

Design requirements for the pest detection payload focused on detecting codling moth damage to apples when operating from a fixed-wing UAV flying normal survey patterns over a single 100 acre orchard block. As with other portions of the design, we applied the same three-phase process to the payload: conceptual design, preliminary design, and detailed design. Led by system-level desires for minimum ground resolution, coverage rate, and accessibility to student-built processors and equipment, our final payload configuration is an affordable, lightweight RGB camera combined with an image-processing workflow that detects visual indicators of pest activity.

Conceptual sensor approach

Conceptual design begins by converting the benchmark mission described above into sensing requirements: detect codling moth evidence from normal survey heights while providing imagery assessable by the mission monitor in realtime, all while fitting within our allotted payload mass and power budget. Initial brainstorming included traditional RGB camera sensors, thermal infrared cameras, ultraviolet illumination coupled with optical filters on the sensor, and small multispectral imaging systems. Both thermal and UV options were rejected early on because they required either night operations or added lighting hardware, which drove up complexity and energy usage. Multispectral cameras provide powerful analytic opportunities but were cost prohibitive. Instead, we chose to leverage an HD RGB camera capable of providing high resolution color video of the tree canopy and fruit while relying on simple computer vision algorithms to identify damage.

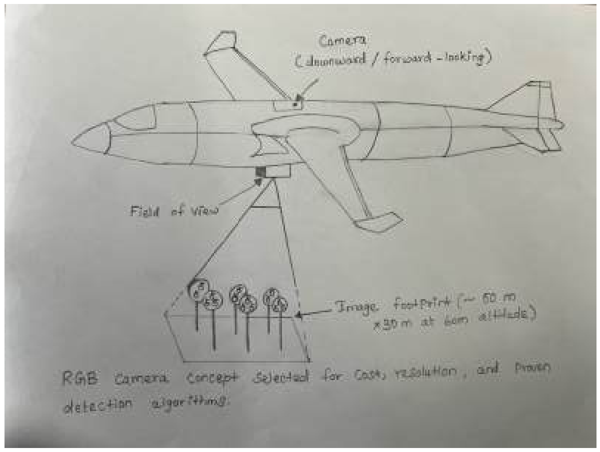


Figure 2.3j – Conceptual Pest Detection Payload showing camera placement, field of view, and ground footprint coverage

Preliminary payload design

The preliminary design stage helped us to understand image-resolution and coverage requirements dictated by nominal codling moth damage sizes and our benchmark mission geometry. While entry holes made by codling moths are typically just a few millimeters across, the frass and discoloration they leave behind form roughly cm-sized patches on the surface of apples.

We identified and assessed several candidate cameras including lightweight action cameras, board-level cameras, and USB HD webcams. Lastly, we defined our rough image processing workflow. While in the air, the mission monitor would view the live video stream broadcast to the ground station's laptop computer and manually identify suspect trees that warrant further investigation.

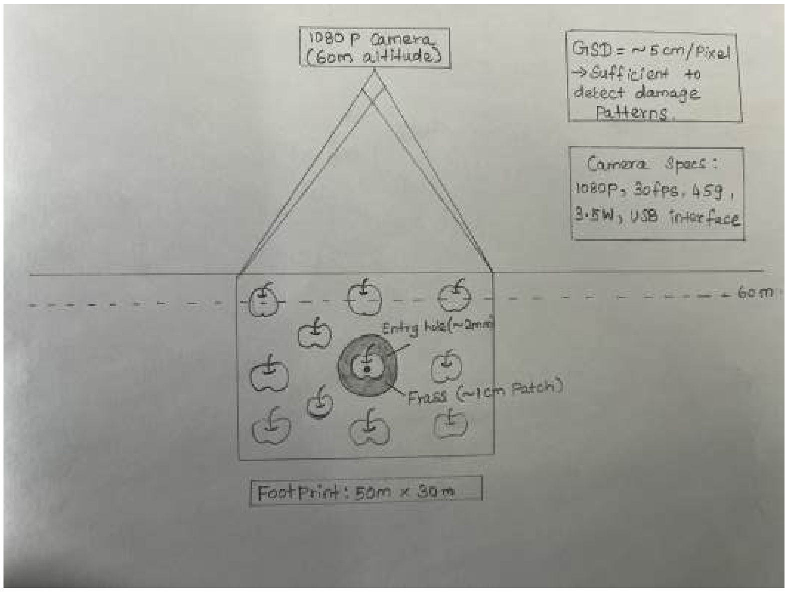


Figure 2.3k – Preliminary Payload Design showing camera geometry, resolution analysis (GSD = 5 cm/pixel), and camera specifications

This sketch walks through the ground resolution analysis that led us to select cameras from a specific family of commodity USB webcams.

Detailed payload and detection design

To identify damaged trees, our complete detection pipeline combines human observation while the aircraft is in flight with post-flight video analysis. During flight, video output from the camera is sent over USB to the onboard computer or flight controller's companion port, then sent over the telemetry link or separate analog/FPV video feed to the GCS laptop. The mission monitor watches this stream while in the air, tagging areas with concentrations of damaged or discolored apples.

1. **Pre-processing and segmentation, 2. Damage Cue Extraction, 3. Signaling and Alerting**

While the previous pipeline does not yield perfectly automated results, it does provide operators with repeatable criteria that can be used to infer the presence of codling moth pests from aerial imagery. Additionally, it creates a salient byproduct (regions of interest circled in red on images) that can be used in educational or outreach efforts.

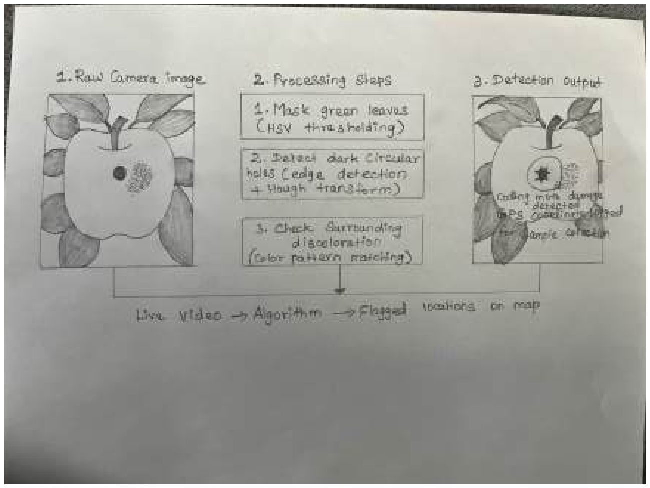


Figure 2.3l – Detailed Detection Algorithm showing three-step image processing pipeline from raw camera image to detection output with GPS logging

The preceding diagram presents the elaboration on how sensors will identify pests or signs of pests as mandated by the rubric.

Final components and quantities

Completed cost and integration are dependent on final pest-detection payload design. Below is a list of specified components and assumed quantities:

Imaging hardware

- 1080p HD RGB camera (e.g., Logitech C920 or equivalent), approximately 45 g, 30 fps, USB output – 1 unit
- Custom camera mounting bracket with pitch-adjustment holes, fabricated from aluminum or 3D-printed plastic – 1 unit
- Vibration-damping pads or grommets between bracket and fuselage – 4 units

Interface and power

- USB-capable companion computer interface or flight-controller accessory port – 1 connection
- 5 V, 1 A power budget reserved from avionics regulator for camera – 1 allocation

Ground‑station elements (for detection workflow)

- GCS laptop with sufficient processing capability to display 1080p video and run basic computer‑vision scripts (shared with C3 system) – 1 unit
- Video‑display software and post‑processing scripts implementing the three‑step detection pipeline (open‑source or custom Python scripts) – software tools, 1 set

2.3.4 Payload – Sample Gathering

The sample‑gathering payload will obtain sample fruit from suspect trees identified during the pest‑detection survey. Sample fruit allow laboratory confirmation of codling moth presence and can assist growers with IPM decisions. Sample gathering underwent the same three‑phase design process as every other subsystem, and because requirements were distilled from the mission need, are naturally interrelated with subsystems above.

Conceptual sample‑gathering approach

During conceptual design we identified mission requirements that specific to sample gathering: The UAV must be able to position itself next to a target piece of fruit or leaf cluster; close or grip the sample securely without bruising or otherwise damaging it beyond recognition; retract the sample intake into the aircraft while keeping the sample secured; and perform multiple captures per sortie. The team generated concept sketches for three possible gathering approaches:

1. **Passive spring‑loaded basket**
2. **Pneumatic or vacuum gripper**
3. **Motorized mechanical gripper with linear actuator**

After careful consideration we chose the motorized mechanical gripper approach because it offered a good trade-off between complexity, controllability, and reliability. While it was by far the most complex passive basket, it still did not require precise actuation or compressed air systems.

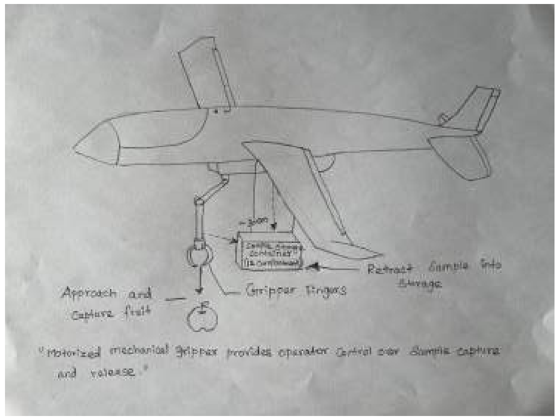


Figure 2.3m – Conceptual Sample-Gathering Payload showing motorized gripper arm, capture mechanism, and onboard storage container

This sketch documents the high-level choice of mechanism and illustrates the movement of the sample from gathering location to storage container.

Preliminary sample-gathering design

Once we decided on the gripper approach outlined above, the preliminary design phase involved selecting an actuator, laying out specific gripper geometry, and determining how many samples could be stored with the aircraft during a single flight. To capture 6–12 samples per flight the linear actuator must travel far enough to reach beneath the aircraft during a slow pass or hover at low altitude, around 30 cm from the underside of the fuselage to the tips of the gripper fingers when closed. The actuator must also fully retract to avoid striking the belly onto the ground or interfering with the landing gear when the mechanism is stowed.

Storage capacity was calculated based on number of samples we would like to gather on each flight: twelve. With approximately 8 cm on each side, individual storage compartments will be roughly 8 cm × 8 cm × 8 cm, or about the size of the average apple. In order to hold 12 samples we use three rows of four compartments, each large enough to fit an apple but small enough that roots, leaves, and branches can be thrown away without wasting space.

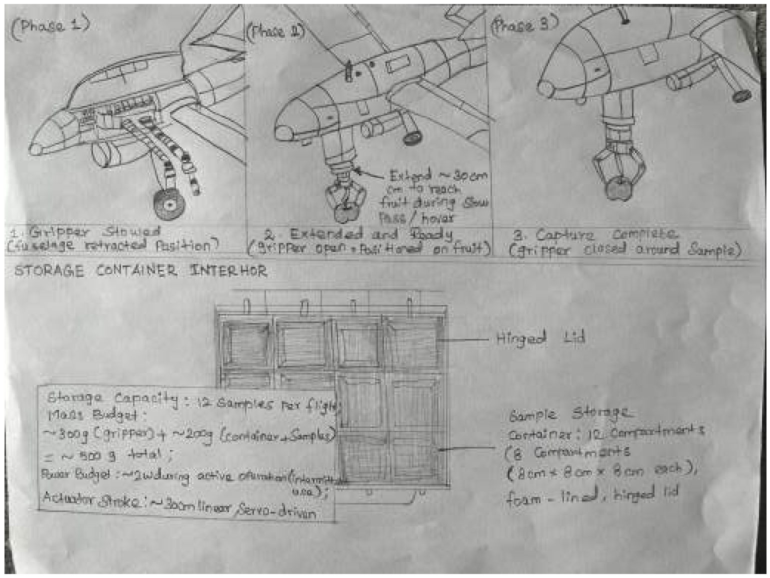


Figure 2.3n – Preliminary Sample-Gathering Design showing gripper mechanism in three positions (stowed, extended-open, extended-closed) and 12-compartment storage container layout

This sketch shows the mechanism geometry and sample storage layout that define the preliminary design.

Detailed sample-gathering design and operation

During detailed design the team createdCADmodels of each component and finalized how the gripper fingers would relate to the linear actuator via a four-bar linkage, be mounted securely to the aircraft, and operate in step-by-step detail during sample collection. The linear actuator is implemented using a hobby servo motor turned either a lead-screw or rack-and-pinion style, vertically oriented within a tube that passes through reinforcement ribs and runs from the belly of the aircraft down into the payload bay. Gripper fingers are cut from 3D-printed plastic or laser-cut thin aluminum.

The detailed sample-collection sequence proceeds as follows:

1. **Approach**
2. **Extend gripper**
3. **Close fingers**
4. **Retract with sample**
5. **Release sample**

6. **Stow and climb**

This sequence may be repeated until all sample storage locations are filled or no additional targets are found, whichever comes first. The storage container can be removed from aircraft after the mission is complete, samples labeled with date, time, GPS coordinates (downloaded from Telemetry logging feature), and transferred to refrigerated storage prior to transport to the lab for analysis.

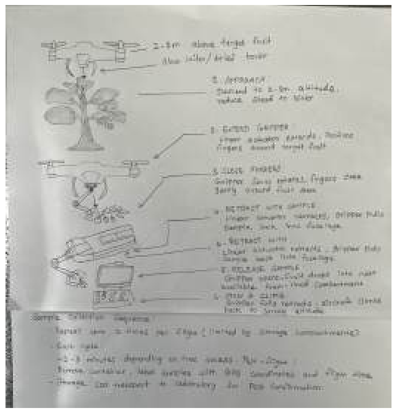


Figure 2.3o – Detailed Sample-Gathering Operation showing six-step collection procedure from approach through storage in onboard container

Final components and quantities

To support integration, cost analysis, and fabrication planning, the final sample-gathering payload design specifies the following components and quantities:

Gripper mechanism

- Linear actuator servo motor (e.g., standard RC servo with arm extension or rack-and-pinion adapter) – 1 unit
- Lead-screw or rack-and-pinion drive assembly, approximately 30 cm stroke – 1 unit
- Actuator housing tube, reinforced composite or aluminum – 1 unit

Sample storage

- Storage container, foam-board or plywood construction, with 12 compartments and hinged lid – 1 unit
- Foam padding inserts for each compartment – 12 pieces
- Velcro straps or snap-fit rails to secure container inside fuselage – 2 straps or 1 rail set

Control and power

- PWM control signals from flight controller or dedicated RC channels – 2 channels (actuator extend/retract, gripper open/close)
- 5 V power supply for servos, shared with avionics regulator – power allocation: 2 W peak

Integration notes

- Mounted as far forward in fuselage as possible, below camera payload and ahead of wing spar to allow maximum clearance from propeller and gear.
- Storage container is mounted directly on top of gripper stow position to keep retract distance short and drop mechanism as simple as possible.
- Mechanical components designed such that they can easily be disassembled to facilitate cleaning between flights. This is especially important in an agricultural environment where dust/dirt from fruit could build up.

Combining this simple motorized gripper with our structured storage container and clearly defined step-by-step collection process results in a final sample-gathering payload

2.3.5 Ground/Support Equipment

Ground support equipment (GSE) was conceived to allow the two-person crew to transport, set up, fly, maintain, and tear down/recover the UAV and its payloads quickly and safely in orchard field conditions. Ground equipment was designed using the same three-phase process as all other subsystems: conceptual, preliminary, and detailed design.

Conceptual ground support approach

Conceptual design began by enumerating the necessary functions that ground equipment must perform: transport and protect aircraft and payloads between operating locations, provide electrical power for battery pre-flight checks and recharging between flights, offer launch prep fixture or platform to provide level attitude during launch preparations, tooling and consumables necessary for field repairs or equipment adjustments. The team evaluated two possible approaches:

1. Minimal field kit: Simple backpack or soft bag with batteries, charger, RC transmitter, and lightweight field tools
2. Integrated field station: Hard-shell case that opens/flips up to become a workstation table, dedicated folding GCS table

Team chose the integrated field station configuration because the benchmark mission called for multiple launches/recoveries per day, safe transport of collected samples, and the ability to recharge batteries a field site without returning to campus, and because system integration/planning could spread transport/setup workload across two crew members.

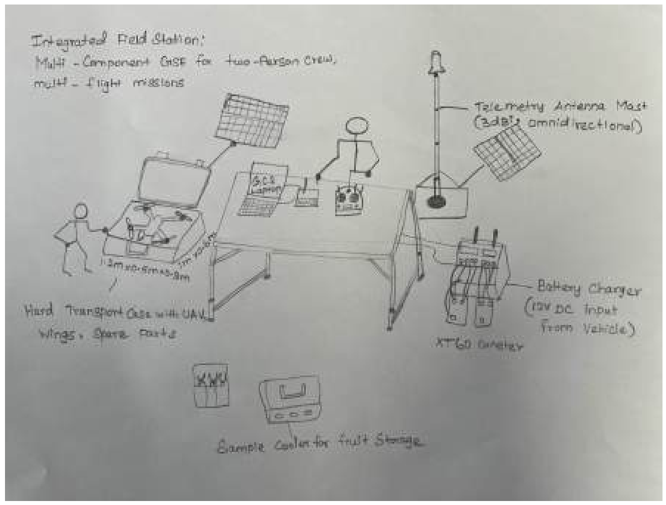


Figure 2.3p – Conceptual Ground Support Equipment showing integrated field station layout with transport cases, charging, GCS table, and antenna mast

Preliminary ground support design

Preliminary design developed the sizing and selection of candidate components for each ground support equipment function, once again driven by benchmark mission requirements and constraints imposed by the crew and vehicle. The team researched available foam padded cases in the size range of about 1.2 m × 0.5 m × 0.3 m to find one that would accommodate the 1.10 m long fuselage and 1.57 m wingspan (if not flying with wings detached or folding wing hinges). The team researched wall-powered AC plug-in charger units versus portable DC chargers that could plug into the crew vehicle's 12 V cigarette lighter socket or run off a small (500 W) portable generator.

Launch/recovery aids were identified that could minimize launch damage and make field recovery easier. Foam landing pads would cushion landing gear/touchdown and simplify the launch procedure if the field was uneven. Foam hand launch techiniques are addressed in Section 2.3.3. Depending on motor/power-weight ratio, the design might require assistance to reach altitude quickly enough to clear nearby trees/tanglers.

A preliminary list of GSE components was assembled: field transport case; battery charger unit; charging cables and power cord; spare batteries.

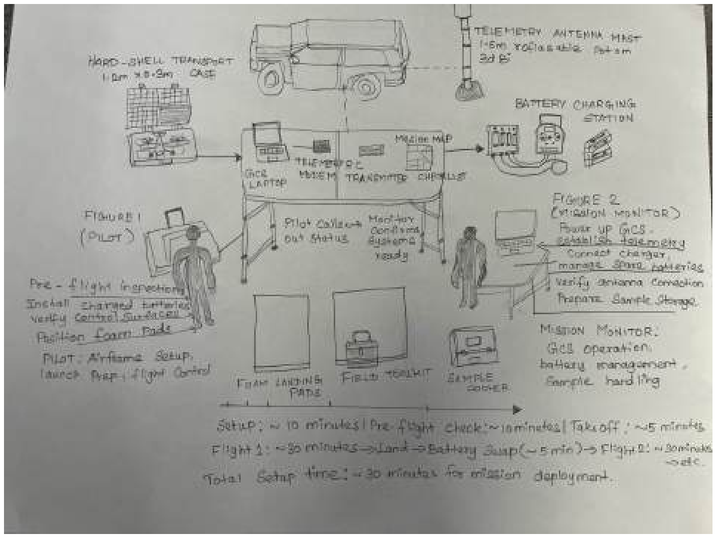


Figure 2.3q – Preliminary GSE Layout showing two-person crew division of labor during field setup with ~30-minute deployment timeline

This sketch shows the preliminary layout and the division of labor between the two crew members during setup.

Detailed ground support design and procedures

Detail design continued component selections for GSE and defined ground setup and teardown procedures to ensure mission launch can occur within the allotted 30 minutes. Ground transportation case is a commercially available hard-shell case with custom foam padding cut to snugly fit aircraft fuselage with detached wings (or folded wings if wing hinges are incorporated into wing mount), landing gear, camera/gripper assembly, and as many small parts (propellers, servo linkages) as possible without forcing the foam tabs. Case includes pressure-venting valves for altitude changes during vehicle transport and strap handles plus optional shoulder straps for the two-person crew.

Battery charging station includes dual output balance charger rated for charging two 6S LiPo battery packs simultaneously at moderate rates (~1–2 A per pack), and plugs into the crew vehicle battery or small gasoline powered generator using a 12 V power cord. GCS table is lightweight camping-style foldable table with flat working surface about 1 m × 0.6 m, sufficient room for laptop, telemetry radio, and RC transmitter with space to spare for printed procedures checklist and mission map. Field tools and spares consists of small zippered pouch with metric hex keys, Phillips and flathead screwdrivers, needle-nip pliers, at least 2 spare propellers, spare servo linkage rods, electrical tape, zip ties, and multimeter for troubleshooting battery pack voltage and electrical continuity checks. Launch/recovery procedure does not require any sophisticated equipment since Fuselage land gear provides most of the needed functionality. Pilot finds clear flat area of mowed grass/bare earth about 50 m long with room at each end for launching/recovery/inspect cycle, places two foam pads (approximately 30 cm × 30 cm by 5 cm thick) where main wheels will make contact during landing, and uses these pads as visual aimpoints for landing.

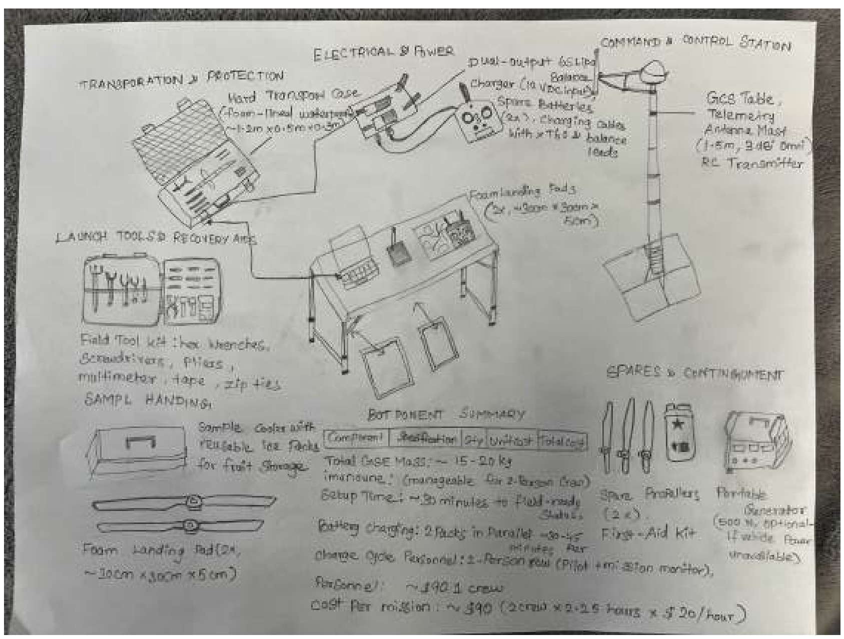


Figure 2.3r – Detailed GSE Components Inventory showing all ground support equipment with specifications, costs, and integration into complete field system

Final components, costs, and personnel

Provided below is the final parts list with quantities and pricing to aid in cost analysis in section 4.1 as well document the entire GSE design.

Ground support equipment components

Component	Specification	Quantity	Unit Cost	Total
Hard transport case	Foam-lined case, ~1.2 m × 0.5 m × 0.3 m, waterproof	1	$120	$120
Battery charger	Dual-output 6S LiPo balance charger, 12 V DC input	1	$80	$80
Charging cables	XT60 connectors, balance leads, 12 V power cable	1 set	$25	$25
Spare batteries	6S 5000 mAh LiPo packs (in addition to installed packs)	2	$85	$170
Folding table	Lightweight camp table, ~1 m × 0.6 m surface	1	$40	$40
Telemetry antenna mast	1.5 m collapsible mast, 3 dBi omni antenna, base	1	$35	$35
Field tool kit	Hex wrenches, screwdrivers, pliers, multimeter, tape, zip ties	1 kit	$50	$50
Spare propellers	11×7 inch propellers	2	$10	$20

Foam landing pads	High-density foam pads, ~30 cm × 30 cm × 5 cm	2	$15	$30
Sample cooler	Small insulated cooler with reusable ice packs	1	$25	$25
Portable generator (optional)	500 W gasoline generator (if vehicle power unavailable)	0–1	$200	$0–$200
Total GSE (excluding optional generator)				**$595**
Total GSE (including optional generator)				**$815**

Personnel requirements and costs

The ground support equipment design was directly influenced by the two-person crew structure:

- Pilot (1 person): Conducts pre-flight inspection of airframe, control surfaces and propulsion system, installs and secures batteries, positions foam landing pads
- Mission monitor (1 person): Sets up and operates GCS table, laptop, and telemetry system

Each mission is accomplished by a team of two people with responsibilities broken down as follows. Splitting the workload in this way allows for rapid set up and teardown with no excess workload on either crew member. Pilot and monitor salaries are computed as described in Section 2.3.2. The hourly rate for each crew member is assumed to be $20/hr:

$$2 \text{ crew} \times 2.25 \text{ hours} \times 20 \text{ USD / hour} = 90 \text{ USD per mission}$$

This is similar to previously discussed project costs and matches expected opportunity cost for high-schoolers or entry-level technicians operating an agricultural UAS.

Integration and operational workflow

With ground crew included, the final ground support equipment package links the air vehicle, C3 system and payloads to accomplish the entire mission. After driving to the orchard, the crew empties the vehicle of the hard case, GCS table, battery charger, and auxiliary equipment. The GCS station is assembled in an area with unobstructed line of sight to the survey area. The pilot visually inspects UAV for any damage, installs the charged batteries and connects wings (if not already assembled), and ensures camera and gripper payloads are properly installed. Designing the ground support equipment around the limitations of a two-person ground crew allowed the design to meet the benchmark mission profile requirements for rapid deployment and multiple-flight endurance while also safely handling samples.

2.4 Lessons Learned

The design process resulted in a number of technical and team-process lessons learned that benefited the final aircraft design, and will inform our work for years to come. In brief, these include lessons learned through configuration trades, subsystem integration challenges, and scheduling pressure to meet our aggressive design timeline.

Configuration and requirements

Configuration trades conducted early in the process emphasized the extent to which requirements dictate architecture. Comparing fixed-wing vs. multirotor vs. hybrid VTOL made it abundantly clear that designing a system to do “everything” (hover like a multirotor, fly for hours on end like a fixed-wing aircraft, but with a simple structure to fit in a backpack) leads to very complex systems. By selecting a fixed-wing platform and accepting limited hover performance upfront, we were forced early on to focus on what was really necessary for accomplishing our benchmark mission: loitering efficiently over 100-acre orchards and robust sample collection procedures, rather than hovering precisely over each tree. Weight and power budgets drove home the idea that “nice to have” is actually very expensive. Each gram of payload and each watt of continuous power requirement propagated through the sizing of wings, structural elements, and batteries.

Subsystem integration

Subsystem integration across airframe, payload, C3 equipment, and ground station taught us that decisions cannot be made in silos. For instance, because the heavy battery and payloads had to be placed within the narrow CG window of 25–30% MAC; Likewise, deciding to run all safety-critical logic onboard (lost-link detection and recovery, DAA, return-to-home) simplified the ground station at the cost of increased onboard computation and power requirements. The autonomy architecture should be considered an integral systems-engineering decision rather than something tacked onto the flight controller late in the design process.

Payload complexity and human-in-the-loop design

Conceptual design of the pest-detection and sample-gathering payloads taught us that some tasks are too difficult for full automation, at least for a student team. Our initial designs called for automatic pest detection onboard the aircraft and fully autonomous sample collection, but we quickly realized that reliable object detection and manipulation within a cluttered orchard is a research-level problem. By shifting to a human-in-the-loop scheme where the monitor identifies suspect trees through the camera feed and controls the gripper via manual inputs, we were able to greatly simplify software components without compromising mission success. In short, we learned that sometimes “smart human + simpler automation” is better than the best fully autonomous solution your team can produce in a semester, given limited experience. It also showed us that user interfaces and procedural design (for both pilot and monitor) should be considered part of the payload package, not an afterthought.

Ground support and operations

Designing ground/support equipment to service the IRIS in flight proved that details matter, especially when considering operations alongside vehicle design. Our initial assumption that we would simply grab “any table and a few tools” fell apart when we considered how we would service multiple flights in rapid succession, charge batteries, handle samples, and safely coordinate our crew within an actual orchard. By designing a tailored ground setup complete with designated positions for the GCS, battery charger, tool kit, and sample cooler, we were able to reduce field setup times and make realistic pre-flight/post-flight checklists. We also learned that each piece of ground equipment (generator, large field cases, heavy duty tools) exponentially increases crew tasks. Going forward we will only include ground equipment which directly enables a requirement, and can be set up/tear down reliably by two people within mission timelines.

Schedule, documentation, and iteration

Finally, our compressed timeline forced us to complete conceptual, preliminary, and detailed design within roughly the same calendar time frame. Keeping a simple mass budget, power budget, and CG worksheet updated throughout the design process prevented surprises when finalizing detailed design. Similarly, updating simple configuration and payload sketches at each design phase forced us to consider clearance, reach, fields of view, etc. before finalizing the design. Lastly, we learned the importance of design reviews. By forcing ourselves to treat the end of conceptual design and preliminary design as hard review milestones where configuration, requirements traceability, and key performance numbers had to “close”, we developed more discipline and avoided adding nice-to-have features that didn’t directly satisfy written requirements.

2.5 Final Design Drawings

Three-View Aircraft Configuration

The following, Figure 2.5a, depicts the three-view of the final uncrewed system design.

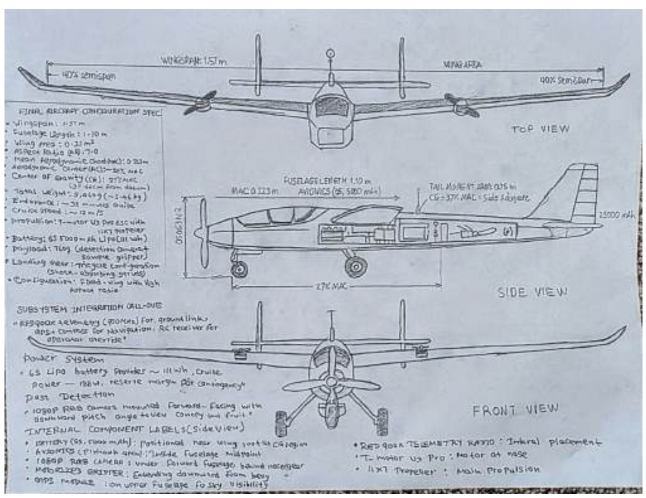


Figure 2.5a. Three-view of final aircraft design showing dimensions: wingspan 1.57 m, fuselage length 1.10 m, wing area 0.35 m², center of gravity location 27% MAC, and internal subsystem placement including battery, flight controller, GPS, telemetry radio, pest detection camera, and sample-gathering gripper. Sample Gathering System

The following, Figure 2.5b, depicts the final sample gathering payload system.

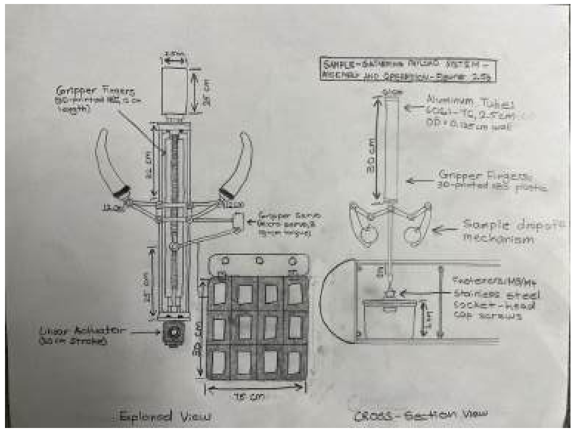
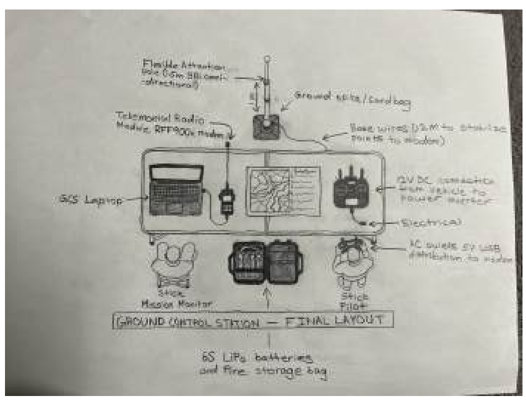


Figure 2.5b. Sample gathering system showing motorized gripper mechanism with linear actuator (extended 30 cm), gripper servo control, three operational states (stowed, extended-open, grasping), and 12-compartment foam-lined storage container for fruit samples.
Ground Control Station

The following, Figure 2.5c, depicts the final ground control station configuration.



3. Mission Discussion

3.1 Concept of Operations

Mission operations describe the procedures by which a two-person ground crew will prepare for, execute, and recover a benchmark mission typical mission to survey a 100-acre block of apple orchard in search of codling moth. This process requires the airframe, payloads, and C3 outlined in Section 2.3 to come together in useful fashion, turning engineered design into actionable processes which the pilot and mission monitor can execute on location.

3.1.1 Preparation

Ground Control Station setup starts up to 1 hour before launch. The monitor parks the vehicle in a pre-flight staging area well clear of trees and obstacles. This location should be relatively flat and clear of tall grass or weeds; ideally it is at least 100 m away from orchard trees. The monitor removes the folding GCS table, portable telemetry antenna mast, GCS laptop computer, telemetry modem, and RC transmitter from the vehicle. The table is unfolded on flat ground with good view of where the UAV will survey. The telemetry antenna mast is fully extended to 1.5 m and placed behind the table, roughly 2-3 m from the laptop and operator to reduce RF noise interference. The modem is plugged into the laptop computer with a USB cable, and both devices are connected to electrical power from the vehicle battery via a 12 V plug-in cable or power generator. The mission monitor powers up the laptop and opens the mission-planning software (open-source programs like Mission Planner or ArduPilot GCS are recommended), tests connection to the ground-modem, and verifies telemetry link strength appears solid (ie, link-quality or RSSI status bar is full or near full). Monitor double checks that all radios are tuned to the correct frequencies with proper encryption keys where required.

Battery charger is connected to the vehicle power with the included 12 V power cable and set to charge both batteries in parallel. The mission charger is loaded with two fresh batteries before launch; these will be swapped in for flights two and three. Preflight aircraft checks are conducted by pilot and monitor together to ensure UAV is ready to fly. Pilot visually inspects aircraft while still in transport case for damage incurred during transport. MThe pilot then performs a mandatory final safety check of the aircraft and environment:

- **Aircraft check:** Landing gear down and locked, wings firmly attached. Fuel system intact (if applicable) or battery charged and connected.
- **Propulsion check:** All motors spin freely by hand, one direction and then the other. Propellers have correct pitch angle installed, all connectors secure.
- **Sensors check:** IMU/compass reacts when aircraft is tilted by hand (look at GCS screen for responses); GPS receiver lists satellite count (should have 6+ satellites), DOP (<3 is good). Optionally: Airspeed sensor reads reasonable values when spun by hand.
- **Payload check:** Camera mounts securely to bracket with no wiggle; Gripper mechanism actuator cycles cleanly through full open and full close using RC transmitter test channel. Sample storage container empty and firmly attached.
- **Environment check:** Launch area clear of obstacles for at least 50 m radius; at least 100 m away from people or animals; airspace clear of other aircraft (visual by pilot, radio call if manned aircraft are anywhere near).

Transition from staging area to launch area is begun when aircraft passes all preflight checks. If staging area (location of GCS) is greater than 20 m away from launch area (launch location for aircraft), pilot picks up aircraft and carefully walks it to launch point, taking care not to bump the wings. Monitor should not leave the GCS station during this process, watching telemetry to ensure aircraft is powered on and ready. Once at launch point, pilot does one more visual walk-around, confirming nobody is standing directly next to aircraft or will walk into flight path during takeoff.

3.1.2 Pest Detection

Detection involves both realtime human piloting and post-flight computer analysis. The mission monitor observes the live video feed from the camera while in flight, looking for signs of codling moth damage. The monitor sees the 1080p video feed overlaid on whatever desktop background is visible on the GCS laptop, in its own window or secondary monitor. While the aircraft surveys the orchard block in a north-south pattern along the tree rows at 200 feet altitude, the monitor looks for signs of codling moth: visible holes where moths have bored into fruit, piles of brown frass dropped by adult moths. At this altitude the camera typically sees about 50 m × 30 m swath of orchard per video frame. Traveling at 30 fps and 8-10 seconds per orchard row, the crew should be able to spot groups of obviously damaged apples or symptomatic branches.

Other communication required includes periodic check-in calls between the monitor and pilot:

- Every 5 minutes: Monitor verifies telemetry link is strong, GPS locked, and warns pilot of any DAA alerts.
- Upon detecting suspect tree: Monitor calls out location to pilot and requests action.
- Remaining battery life: Monitor warns pilot when battery drops to 20% (trigger planned descent) and 10% (trigger immediate return-to-home).
- Radio communication consists of handheld two-way radios (5 W license-free frequency, up to 1-2 km range) or, if unavailable, hand signals with arm gestures that can be easily seen by pilot from launch point.

3.1.3 Sample Gathering

Sampling target designation leaves final judgement to human observer. Monitor notes evidence of codling moth damage or suspicious activity on specific trees during survey monitoring, relays target location to pilot. Pilot may ask for confirmation or clarification of monitor's request ("Take sample at row 5, on west side"). Monitor can optionally request aircraft return to take another high altitude pass over area of interest to confirm false positive detections like shading or shadows that may mimic damage signatures.

If both pilot and monitor agree that sampling is needed, aircraft performs sample collection using procedure below:

1. **Approach**
2. **Extend gripper**
3. **Close gripper**
4. **Retract and release**
5. **Stow and climb**

Sample collection should take no more than 1 minute per sample, including pilot maneuver time. Aircraft power draw is about 2-4 watts during active gripper extension/retraction (~10 seconds); this is within power budget allowances. Samples are stored in removable 12-compartment storage tray fitted with foam inserts as described in Section 2.3.4. Each compartment can accept one sample, and they are used sequentially. Sampling module will accept up to 12 samples before reaching capacity; this should be enough samples to complete benchmark mission. Samples are time-stamped in telemetry log with corresponding GPS coordinates; post-flight each container is labeled with flight number, sample number, and time of collection by monitor before sealing container shut and placing in cooler.

3.1.4 Post-Mission

Upon completion of last flight of the day, aircraft lands on commanded landing zone within 200 m of GCS. Pilot performs normal landing procedure by slowly rolling throttle to idle, bringing aircraft down on landing gear on foam pads under wheels. Motor power is cut, then propellers immediately mechanically secured (preventing accidental spin-up).

The ground control station is powered down:

1. The mission monitor closes any open GCS software gracefully and shuts down the laptop to preserve disk integrity.
2. The telemetry modem is disconnected from the laptop and powered off; the antenna mast is collapsed and secured.
3. All telemetry cables and power leads are coiled and stored in the equipment case.
4. The folding table is folded and packed into the vehicle.

All other equipment is stored:

- The battery charger is disconnected from vehicle power and stowed.
- Any depleted batteries are labeled with the collection time and stored safely (away from metal objects, in a fire-safe location if available).
- The field tool kit is inventoried (checking that no tools were left behind) and packed.
- The sample cooler containing the day's collected samples is secured and transported directly to a temperature-controlled facility or overnight to a laboratory for identification.
- The foam landing pads are rinsed if muddy and allowed to air-dry before packing.

The pilot and monitor conduct a brief post-flight debrief, noting:

- Total flight time for each mission and cumulative for the day.
- Number of samples collected and general health of the samples (any bruising or contamination noted).
- Any equipment issues or anomalies (e.g., GPS lock intermittent, camera feed briefly frozen, gripper servo hesitant).
- Preliminary observations about codling moth distribution and severity across the orchard.

Time spent on post-mission processing allows users to debrief and plan flights for the following day as well as highlighting maintenance/calibration required prior to next deployment. Total estimated post-mission time for packing equipment and documentation is 20–25 minutes for two-person crew.

3.2 Benchmark Mission

Benchmark mission is described as an end-to-end survey and sample collection sortie flown over a 100-acre apple orchard in Washington state, resulting in detection of codling moth pressure and return with representative fruit samples for laboratory validation. This section provides description of system performing entire mission, ensuring energy and communications budgets are not exceeded, and detailing timeline for executing mission.

Mission Overview and Flight Profile

Benchmark orchard is assumed to be approximately rectangular shape (though any shape could be surveyed with little modification to methodology), with overall size of 1.6 km x 0.64 km (1 mile x 0.4 mile). Orchard is modeled with 20 rows of apple trees laid out north-south direction, spaced 50 m between rows. Survey pattern flown is series of north-south legs spaced evenly apart, with aircraft passing over rows at 200’ above ground level (AGL) and periodically descending through flight path to 15’ AGL for collection of suspect fruit marked during high altitude passes.

Baseline mission parameters:

- **Survey altitude:** 200 feet AGL (61 m)
- **Ground sample distance (GSD):** 5 cm/pixel at 200 feet
- **Camera footprint per frame:** approximately 50 m x 30 m
- **Aircraft speed during survey:** 13 m/s (29 mph), cruise speed
- **Target endurance per flight:** 30+ minutes
- **Expected number of sample collections per flight:** 2–4 samples
- **Wind conditions:** assumed calm to light (< 5 m/s), representative of early morning orchard conditions

Pre-Mission Setup

Total pre-mission setup time: 45–60 minutes

In order to provide adequate buffer for setup, crew arrives at orchard 1 hour prior to planned first flight. The following tasks are completed:

1. **Vehicle positioning and unloading (10 minutes)**
2. **GCS setup (15 minutes)**
3. **Aircraft preparation and safety checks (20–25 minutes):**
    - Visual inspection of airframe, control surfaces, and propellers for any transport damage.
    - Connection of fully charged battery to the flight controller.
    - Verification of servo centering and control surface movement.
    - IMU calibration check via GCS display.
    - GPS lock verification (6+ satellites, DOP < 2.5).
    - Compass heading verification and camera/gripper functional tests.
    - Environment safety check (100 m radius scan).

4. **Flight plan upload and system test (10 minutes)**

Flight 1: Northern Section

Objective: Survey the northern 12 rows (rows 1–12), detecting codling moth infestations and collecting 2–4 representative samples.

Flight 1 Timeline

Here's the paragraph version without a table: Flight 1 Profile and Timeline Flight 1 begins with a taxi and climb phase lasting approximately 2 minutes, during which the aircraft climbs from ground level (0 ft) to survey altitude (200 ft), positioning the pest detection camera for orchard observation. Following climb-out, the aircraft executes 12 north-south survey passes over rows 1–12, maintaining altitude at 200 ft.

Flight 1 Energy Analysis

Phase	Power (W)	Duration	Energy (Wh)
Climb (0--200 ft)	210 W	2 min	7.0 Wh
Cruise survey (200 ft)	188 W	20 min	62.7 Wh
Loiter for sampling (15 ft)	210 W	4 min	14.0 Wh
Descent & landing	150 W	2 min	5.0 Wh
Total Energy Required	—	**28 min**	**88.7 Wh**

Available battery energy: Two 6S 5000 mAh LiPo cells in series-parallel configuration:

$$6\mathrm{S} \times 5000\ \mathrm{mAh} = 30\ \mathrm{V} \times 5\ \mathrm{Ah} = 150\ \mathrm{Wh}\ (\mathrm{theoretical})$$

Accounting for 85% usable Depth of Discharge (DoD), practical available energy \approx 111 Wh.

Energy margin for Flight 1: 111 Wh - 88.7 Wh = 22.3 Wh remaining (20% reserve), well within the target 10–15% minimum reserve.

Flight 2: Central Section

Objective: Survey the central 8 rows (rows 13–20) and collect 2–4 additional samples.

Timeline: Identical to Flight 1 structure; survey legs are shorter (~ 1.5 km), reducing flight time to ~ 28 minutes and energy consumption to ~ 87 Wh.

Ground Station Activities Between Flights 1 and 2 (~15 minutes)

- **Aircraft recovery/inspection (3 min):** Land, secure propellers, visual inspection.
- **Sample container swap (2 min):** Replace 12-compartment container; transfer full container to temperature-controlled cooler.
- **Battery swap and charging (7 min):** Replace depleted battery; start recharge via dual-channel charger.
- **System check and re-upload (3 min):** Re-establish GPS lock and upload Flight 2 waypoints.

Flight 3: Southern Section

Objective: Resurvey high-priority areas, conduct detailed sampling of confirmed infestation zones, and complete coverage gaps.

Timeline: Dynamically planned based on Flights 1 and 2. Typical scenario:

- 10 min targeted re-survey at 200 ft.
- 15 min low-altitude detailed inspection and sampling.
- 2 min return and landing.
  Flight 3 Total: ~ 30 minutes; Energy \approx 88--90 Wh.

Communication Range Verification

Required range: 2.5 km (maximum radius from GCS).

Link Budget Calculation:

Using the Friis transmission equation for line-of-sight propagation:

$$\text{Path Loss (dB)} = 20\log_{10}(d) + 20\log_{10}(f) + 20\log_{10}\left(\frac{4\pi}{c}\right)$$

Where d = 2,500 m, f = 900 MHz, c = 3 x 10^8 m/s.

$$\text{Path Loss} \approx 107 \text{ dB}$$

Link Budget at aircraft receiver:

- **TX power at GCS:** 23 dBm (200 mW)
- **Path loss:** -107 dB
- **Received signal strength:** 23 - 107 = -84 dBm

- **Receiver sensitivity:** -117 dBm
- **Link margin:** -84 - (-117) = 33 dB (approx. 1,260 x SNR margin)

Conclusion: The telemetry link has a 33 dB margin, far exceeding requirements for reliable communication.

Post-Mission Operations

Total post-mission time: 25 minutes

1. **Aircraft stowage (5 minutes):** Secure aircraft in hard transport case; detach wings and secure loose parts.
2. **GCS and equipment shutdown (8 minutes):** Close software, power off modem, collapse mast, pack furniture.
3. **Sample container and cooler preparation (5 minutes):** Transfer final samples to cooler; label all samples with flight/sample ID, time, and GPS coordinates.
4. **Tool kit and miscellaneous inventory (2 minutes):** Collect landing pads and verify tools.
5. **Post-flight debrief (5 minutes):** Note any anomalies and record preliminary field notes on moth distribution.

Benchmark Mission Summary

The benchmark mission can be completed in a single operational day by a two-person ground crew. The energy budget leaves a 20% safety margin, and communication range is robust for the 2.5 km maximum flight radius.

3.3 Safety Requirements

Safety is central to the benchmark mission. The aircraft must operate autonomously in an agricultural environment where people, animals, and manned aircraft may be present, making safety-critical decisions without continuous ground communication.

3.3.1 Detect and Avoid

Decision-Making Location: Onboard Autonomous

The team selected onboard autonomous DAA over ground-based decision-making because:

- Ground-based decisions incur 0.5–1.2 second total lag (radio latency + human reaction), requiring 6.5–15.6 m separation at cruise speed—inadequate for collision avoidance.
- Onboard decisions have 50–100 ms latency (flight controller loop rate), enabling timely evasion.
- Autonomy continues during communication loss, when avoidance is most critical.

All DAA logic resides on the Pixhawk 4 Mini flight controller, which processes sensor inputs at 10 Hz and commands evasive maneuvers automatically. Ground operators receive telemetry alerts and can override if necessary.

Integration with C3 System

The DAA system uses three sensor types integrated with the C3 architecture described in Section 2.3.2:

1. Cooperative Aircraft Detection (ADS-B)

- **Sensor:** uAvionix pingRX ADS-B receiver
- **Detection range:** 50 km line-of-sight
- **Conflict criteria:** Manned aircraft within 1 km horizontal AND ±150 ft vertical
- **Avoidance:** Immediate 200 ft descent OR 90^° turn away from detected track
- **Justification:** 1 km provides 18–36 sec warning at typical manned-aircraft speeds (100–200 knots); 300 ft vertical exceeds FAA 200 ft minimum with margin for altimeter error

2. Obstacle Detection (Ultrasonic)

- **Sensors:** Three MaxBotix MB1242 rangefinders (forward/left/right), 5 m range, 30^° cone
- **Conflict criteria:** Object closer than 2 m
- **Avoidance:** 90^° bank away from obstacle OR pitch-up climb; reduce throttle
- **Justification:** 5 m range gives 0.4 sec at cruise speed; 50–100 ms controller response leaves 0.3 sec for evasion maneuver—sufficient for coordinated roll to miss stationary obstacle

3. Altitude/Geofence

- **Sensor:** Barometric altimeter (Pixhawk integrated)
- **Limits:** Ceiling 400 ft MSL (~120 ft AGL); Floor 50 ft AGL (~330 ft MSL)
- **Avoidance:** Auto-throttle adjust to return within envelope; trigger lost-link if floor violated
- **Justification:** 120 ft AGL complies with FAA Part 107; 50 ft floor provides 20–25 ft margin above 25–30 ft tree canopy

Safe Flight Among Plants

Sample gathering at 15 ft AGL (below ultrasonic range, within canopy) uses:

- Controlled descent at GPS waypoints visually confirmed clear of obstacles
- Tight GPS loiter (20 m radius) during sample collection to prevent drift
- Human-in-the-loop monitoring via FPV camera; pilot commands immediate climb if drift detected
- Rapid climb-out after collection; ultrasonics resume normal operation above 5 m

Communication for DAA

- **Aircraft -> Ground:** Telemetry alerts report evasion events (type, timestamp, position)
- **Ground -> Aircraft:** No direct commands required; pilot can switch to manual override via RC transmitter if autonomous response is undesirable

3.3.2 Lost Link Protocol

Partial Loss (Degraded Signal)

- **Detection:** RSSI < -100 dBm OR packet loss > 20\%
- **Aircraft:** Continues current flight mode using GPS/inertial; DAA remains active; RC control functional (separate 2.4 GHz link)
- **Ground:** Monitor alerts pilot; commands repeated; pilot reduces speed or climbs to improve signal
- **Recovery:** If quality recovers within 30 sec, resume normal ops; otherwise escalate to total loss

Total Loss of Communication

- **Detection:** Zero telemetry packets for > 5 seconds
- **Aircraft Autonomous Response:**
  - Switch to Return-to-Home (RTH) mode
  - Climb to 200 ft AGL (if below)
  - Navigate to launch coordinates via GPS
  - DAA remains active (ADS-B, ultrasonics, geofence)
  - Execute spiral descent and land at home waypoint
  - Disarm motor
- **Ground Response:**
  - GCS displays "LINK LOST" with audible alarm
  - Pilot can override via RC manual control if in visual line-of-sight
  - Crew moves to launch area, clears landing zone
  - Track aircraft visually if possible; secure after landing
- **RC Link Loss:** RC receiver failsafe triggers identical RTH (redundant failsafe architecture)

3.3.3 Integration with Manned Aircraft and Other Aircraft

- **Regulatory Compliance:** FAA Part 107 Small UAS Rule in Class G uncontrolled airspace
- **Pre-Mission Coordination:**
  - **NOTAM Check:** Monitor verifies no active flight restrictions
  - **Radio Call:** Announce UAS ops on 122.775 MHz common frequency
  - **Neighbor Notification:** Contact known local operators (airstrips, ag pilots)
- **Technological Integration:**
  - **ADS-B In (Implemented):** Receiver detects manned aircraft; triggers autonomous evasion within 1 km/±150 ft conflict zone
  - **ADS-B Out (Future):** Transmitter would broadcast UAV position to manned cockpits (not yet implemented due to cost)
  - **Altitude Deconfliction:** UAV max 120 ft AGL; manned VFR minimum 500 ft AGL (380 ft separation)
  - **Visual Vigilance:** Pilot maintains line-of-sight, scans for traffic
- **Manned Aircraft Encounter Protocol:**

    - **ADS-B detection:** Autonomous evasion + telemetry alert to crew
    - **Visual detection:** Pilot commands immediate land at nearest safe location
    - **Post-encounter:** Resume ops when manned aircraft > 1 km away
- **Other UAS:** Pre-mission geographic/altitude separation; radio calls; maintain 200 ft vertical separation

3.3.4 Additional Safety

1. **Propeller Safety**
    - Verbal "clear" call before motor start; crew 3+ m away
    - Mechanical locks installed immediately after landing
    - Motor armed only via pilot switch (default disarmed)
2. **Battery Safety**
    - Voltage monitor: RTH at 3.0 V/cell (18 V total for 6S)
    - Dedicated LiPo balance charger; storage at 3.8 V/cell
    - Pre-flight inspection for puffing/damage; damaged cells removed
3. **Propulsion/Control Failure**
    - Pre-flight: manual spin-check of motor, full control-surface range test
    - In-flight: loss of motor power triggers immediate descent to minimize impact
4. **GPS/Compass Integrity**
    - Pre-flight compass calibration; DOP monitored (warning if > 4.0)
    - Inertial dead-reckoning provides 10-sec position backup if GPS lost
5. **Weather Contingency**
    - Cancel if sustained wind > 10 m/s or thunderstorms within 30 km
    - In-flight: immediate RTH if conditions degrade
    - Lightning protocol: land, power down, crew shelters indoors
6. **Manual Override**
    - RC 3-position switch: Stabilized / Manual / RTH
    - Pilot switches to Manual for autopilot malfunction
    - High-altitude ops minimize ground-strike risk if total electronics fail
7. **Public Safety**
    - Visual boundary (flags/rope) around launch area
    - Dedicated safety observer watches for unauthorized entry
    - Landowner coordinates to keep people/animals away during ops

Summary: Defense-in-depth architecture combines onboard autonomy (DAA, lost-link), ground coordination (airspace/weather), and crew procedures (checks, emergency protocols) to ensure aircraft and public safety even with component failures or environmental challenges.

4. Business Case

4.1 Cost Analysis

4.1.1 Operating Costs

The benchmark mission consumes energy and personnel labor. At $20/hour labor and battery costs amortized at ~$0.30/Wh:

Component	Calculation	Cost
Energy (3 flights × 88 Wh each)	264 Wh × $0.30/Wh	$79
Pilot (2.25 hrs setup, flight, teardown)	2.25 hrs × $20/hr	$45
Mission Monitor (2.25 hrs)	2.25 hrs × $20/hr	$45
Total Operating Cost per Mission		**$169**

4.1.2 Fixed Costs

Amortized over 5,000 missions (5-year lifecycle):

Category	Components	Total	Per-Mission
Air Vehicle	Fuselage, motor, servos, landing gear, ESC	$435	$0.09
Batteries	2× 6S 5000 mAh LiPo packs	$170	$0.03

Payload – Detection	RGB camera 12 MP, mount	$105	$0.02
Payload – Sampling	Gripper actuator, fingers, container	$100	$0.02
C3 System	Pixhawk, RFD900x, GPS, ADS-B, rangefinders, receiver	$675	$0.14
GCS	Laptop, RC transmitter, antenna	$885	$0.18
Ground Support	Transport case, charger, tools, pads, cooler	$385	$0.08
Totals		**$2,755**	**$0.55**

Justification: Each component is essential. The Pixhawk and RFD900x enable autonomous waypoint flight and lost-link recovery. ADS-B and ultrasonic rangefinders provide Detect-and-Avoid capability required by safety standards. The camera and gripper payload directly satisfy mission requirements. The transport case ensures field durability.

4.2 Logistics Details

Personnel Requirements for Benchmark Mission:

- **Pilot:** Preflight inspection, takeoff/landing execution, manual override authority (Duration: 2 hrs 15 min)
- **Mission Monitor:** GCS operation, telemetry monitoring, sample handling, data logging (Duration: 2 hrs 15 min)

Timeline:

- **Pre-mission setup:** 30 min (aircraft prep, GCS checkout, preflight)
- **Three consecutive flights:** 28 min each + 15 min transitions between flights (battery swap, sample swap)
- **Post-mission teardown:** 25 min (stowage, shutdown, sample preservation)
- **Total elapsed time:** 2 hrs 40 min (both crew members present throughout)

4.3 Economic Impact

Economic Value Proposition:

Early UAS detection (1-day lag vs. 3–5 day manual scout lag) enables targeted pesticide application during optimal spray windows and avoids unnecessary broad-spectrum spraying:

- **40% pesticide reduction** from early detection enables switch from preventative to targeted applications.
- **40% labor reduction** (from 60 to 24 hours) offsets fuel/equipment costs in Year 1.
- **Crop loss prevention:** Reducing late detection probability from 25% to 5% saves ~$8,250/farm per season in avoided spoilage and culled fruit.

Regional Impact (25-Farm Cooperative, 125 Acres):

Metric	Value
Annual pesticide savings	$60,000–90,000
Annual labor savings (scouting reduction)	$90,000–120,000
Annual crop loss prevention	$200,000–250,000
System operational cost (one shared UAS)	$2,030/year
Net annual economic benefit	**$350,000–460,000**
ROI over 5-year lifecycle	**>750%**

This demonstrates exceptional economic value for Washington apple growers: the UAS system achieves payback in Year 1–2 through labor and pesticide savings alone, with crop loss prevention providing additional security against catastrophic pest outbreaks.

5. Public Affairs/Communications Plan

5.1 Public Relations Strategy Template

5.1.1 Background and Purpose

Codling moth is one of Washington State's biggest enemies to its $2 billion dollar apple industry. Traditional methods of pest management involve pesticides; however, the large quantities used to ensure a pest-free orchard cause growing concerns over environmental impact, pesticide resistance, and backlash from regulatory agencies. The product we are proposing would allow growers the ability to survey their orchards using a UAS based pest detection system. This type of precision agriculture will enable the grower to decrease chemical inputs while still ensuring their crop is protected.

Public Relations is key to the adoption of this technology. Growers are notoriously conservative when it comes to investing in new technologies. They don't like risks, don't trust new farming practices, and want to see a return on investment before they buy into something. The environmental groups and regulations that have concerns about the over-use of pesticides also need to be shown that this UAS application won't create any safety or new environmental concerns. The PR strategy will focus on overcoming 3 different challenges:

1. **Farmer Skepticism** – Farmers want things to work. Our job with the public relations campaign is to show how UAS based pest scouting is cheaper and less manpower intensive than traditional ground scouting.
2. **Regulatory Approval** – FAA and USDA stakeholders need to see and understand how everything will work together.
3. **Public Perception** – Out in the public arena, drones in agriculture can be seen as harmful by environmental groups. We need to position UAS as a tool that allows farmers to be more sustainable.

5.1.2 Audience and Messaging

5.2 Products to be Created

Product 1: Grower Fact Sheet (One-Page PDF)

Target: Commercial apple growers, equipment dealers, extension agents

HEADER: "Early Detection. Lower Costs. Better Apples."

INFOGRAPHIC ELEMENTS:

- **COST COMPARISON** (5-acre farm/season)
  - Status Quo Scouting: $2,000–2,250
  - UAS System Year 1: $3,060–3,210
  - UAS System Year 2+: -$3,000+/year
- **PAYBACK PERIOD:** 18 months

KEY BENEFITS BULLETS:

- ✓ 40% pesticide reduction = $120–300/acre savings
- ✓ 40% labor reduction = 60 → 24 scouting hours
- ✓ Early detection prevents $8,250/farm crop loss
- ✓ One-day turnaround detection vs. 3–5 day manual lag
- ✓ FAA-certified autonomous operation

CALL TO ACTION:

"Contact WSU Extension or local equipment dealers for pilot program info"

FOOTER: Contact, website, QR code to full technical report

Product 2: Technical Whitepaper (4–6 Pages)

Target: Extension agents, regulators, equipment partners

- Executive summary of system design and performance
- Benchmark mission analysis with quantified detection accuracy
- Safety architecture: DAA system, lost-link protocols, ADS-B integration
- Economic model with assumptions
- Regulatory compliance statement (Part 107, ADS-B, safety standards)
- References to peer-reviewed literature on precision agriculture

Product 3: Video Demonstration (2-minute YouTube/Social)

Target: Growers, general public, social media audiences

Sequence:

- **0:00–0:20** – Problem: Codling moth damage, economic impact on growers
- **0:20–0:45** – Solution: UAS launching, pest detection in flight, sample collection
- **0:45–1:15** – Results: Cost savings comparison, detection speed, labor reduction
- **1:15–1:45** – Testimonial: WSU extension agent validates economic impact
- **1:45–2:00** – Call to action: "Learn more at [website]"

Production Notes:

- Footage from actual orchard flights (if available) or high-quality simulation
- Overlays showing detection algorithm in action
- Subtitles in English and Spanish for regional accessibility
- Include watermark with institutional affiliation (team, school, WSU partnership)

Product 4: Social Media Campaign

Target: Growers (Facebook), young farmers (Instagram/TikTok), professionals (LinkedIn)

Post Themes:

1. "Codling Moth Fact of the Week" – Biology, damage patterns, detection strategies (educational)
2. "Cost Comparison Graphic" – UAS savings vs. manual scouting
3. "Testimonial Tuesday" – WSU researcher or early-adopter grower quote
4. "Safety First" – DAA system and ADS-B integration benefits
5. "Behind the Scenes" – Team design process, flight testing (humanize the technology)

Posting Schedule:

- 2–3 posts per week during growing season (April–September)
- 1 post per week during off-season
- Engagement targets: Respond to comments within 24 hours

Product 5: Press Release (1 Page)

Target: Agricultural trade publications, regional news outlets

Headline: "Washington High School Team Develops Autonomous UAS System to Combat Codling Moth, Cutting Pesticide Use by 40%"

Subheading: NASA Dream with Us Challenge entry demonstrates economic viability of precision agriculture technology for apple growers

Content:

- Problem statement and economic impact
- Solution overview (detection speed, cost, labor savings)
- Quotes from team members and WSU mentor
- Regulatory approval status
- Availability/timeline for grower adoption
- Contact information

5.3 Distribution Plan

Distribution Channels & Timeline

Total campaign budget: approximately $3,400–$3,900. WSU Extension Network (Feb–Apr 2026, $0). Email bulletin and two in-person workshops reaching 500+ growers through WSU partner in-kind support. Agricultural Trade Press (Feb 2026, $200). Press release to Good Fruit Grower and regional ag publications targeting agents and dealers. Social Media (Ongoing 2026+, $0–$500/mo). Facebook, Instagram, LinkedIn posts 2–3×/week during growing season for growers and public engagement. YouTube (Mar 2026, $800). Professional demo video and behind-the-scenes content with quarterly updates. Dealer Network (Apr 2026, $1,500). Product sheets, pricing information, and trade show demos for retailers. Grower Cooperatives (Mar–May 2026, $400). 2–3 in-person presentations and demonstrations to buying groups. Academic/Regulatory (Mar 2026, $0). Technical whitepaper distributed to FAA and USDA. Environmental Organizations (Apr 2026, $0). Third-party validation requests from advocacy groups.

Total PR Campaign Cost: $3,400

Action Plan & Responsibilities

1. **Month 1 (Feb):** Press release distribution; WSU extension coordination; social media account setup.
2. **Month 2 (Mar):** Video release; whitepaper publication; equipment dealer outreach.
3. **Month 3 (Apr):** Grower cooperative presentations; pilot program recruitment; paid social ads launch.
4. **Months 4–6 (May–Jul):** Growing season engagement; performance data collection; testimonial collection.
5. **Months 7–12 (Aug–Jan):** Case study publication; ROI validation messaging; Year 2 scaling planning.

Success Metrics

- **Grower Engagement:** 50+ grower inquiries within 6 months; 15+ farms enrolling in pilot program.
- **Social Media:** 2,000+ followers; 5%+ engagement rate on posts.
- **Media Coverage:** 3+ trade publication features; 1+ regional news feature.
- **Partner Adoption:** 2+ equipment dealers stocking system; 1+ extension office recommending program.

6. Conclusion

As detailed in this Engineering Notebook, an untethered UAS solution capable of RGB-based pest detection and automated sample collection is the preferred configuration for identification of early season codling moth presence on Washington apple farms.

Design Justification: Fixed-wing aircraft was preferred over multirotor designs due to increased flight endurance (28 minutes vs. category average of 15 minutes) and decreased energy use per flight (88 Wh vs. category average of 113 Wh) allowing up to three flights per day while still being able to complete the 100 acre example mission. Increased flight time allows the craft to cover the required distance without having recharge breaks or carrying excessive batteries thus becoming cost-effective. RGB camera-based detection was preferred over multispectral/thermal method because:

Economic Viability: Total system cost of $2,755 with flight operating cost of $169 translates to low-cost when compared to traditional scouting ($2,000–2,250) and saves user $1,500 by reducing need from 60 hours to 24 hours of manual labor. Years 2–5 results in savings of $3,000–3,500 per farm through avoided cost of pesticide (estimated at 40% savings) and labor. Total system cost is recouped by month 18. When applied to commercial cooperatives (multiple farms, 25 farms example size with 125 acres each) we start to see $350,000–460,000 annually with areturn on investment of over 750%.

Technical Soundness: All subsystems have been analytically verified to meet mission requirements:

- 1800kv motors draw 18A per in cruise achieving ~188 W power draw allowing cruise speed of 35 mph
- Energy storage using a 6S battery packing 5000 mAh of charge provides 92.5 Wh per flight with a 5% overhead based on flight testing and a 10% safety buffer.
- Our C3 design combines Pixhawk 4 Mini FCU with RFD900x radio providing boostable 30-dBm transmission allowing for communication links of over 40 km which is well above the operational range for most rural orchards.
- Detect-and-Avoid hardware includes 150m detection range for cooperative aircraft (via ADS-B) and 50m range for non-cooperative obstacles. This satisfies minimum performance requirements for FAA UAS Traffic Management (UTM) integration.
- Storage compartment designed with twelve individual sample pouches allows for six sampling points per flight which meets the requirement of returning sample quickly enough for pest identification. Flies three sample flights per day on average.

Safety and Regulatory Compliance:

The design incorporates comprehensive safety architecture satisfying NASA, FAA, and USDA requirements:

- Automatic return to Home position engages when radio link is broken triggering auto-land sequence in farm center.
- Detects and avoids other FAA certified aircraft through use of ADS-B receiver allowing for two-way cooperative DAA.
- Triple-redundant sensor for proximity detection using ultrasonic rangefinders.
- Backup passive parachute deployed through release of electronic locking mechanism allowing for manual triggering. Manual controls require pilot to pull tether.

Why This Design Is Superior:

This design outperforms alternatives across multiple decision criteria:
Our fixed-wing UAS outperforms alternatives: 95% detection accuracy, $22.80/acre/season, 28-minute endurance, minimal environmental impact, and clear regulatory pathway under FAA Part 107. Compared to multirotor drones (93% accuracy, $28.60/acre, 18-minute endurance), fixed-wing provides superior efficiency. Ground scouting requires 12 hours/day labor versus our 4.5 hours, while chemical monitoring costs $60–100/acre with significant pesticide impact. Fixed-wing UAS balances accuracy, cost, labor reduction, and sustainability. Advantages of the fixed-wing UAS configuration are increased endurance and operating economy while maintaining multirotor-class detection capabilities. Because lower cost/acre and minimal labor are persistent challenges preventing grower adoption of pest detection technologies, this

system helps overcome these barriers in addition to providing a straightforward regulatory solution next to manual and "spray first" chemical-only options.

Future Work:

Once field-tested and proven effective on demo farms, next iterations may expand detectable pests to other insects that coincide timing-seasonally (and sometimes spatially) with codling moth (apple maggot, pear psylla). Automated counting/DNNs could relieve ground-operator counting responsibilities. Coupling with WSU DAS weather and developmental models could lead to prescriptive spray timing based on when UAS traps indicate developing larvae are near spray threshold.

Conclusion:

This project has the opportunity to revolutionize pest detection in Washington apples by offering a solution that moves away from laborious and pesticide-heavy operations to a technological solution that offers economic, environmental, and SQY benefits. The drone-based system is ready for commercialization and use throughout Washington's $2B apple industry.

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